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Eagle Scouts and the Contributing Factors to Civic Engagement on the College Campus

By

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Submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements

For the degree of Doctorate of Education in Interdisciplinary Leadership

With a focus on Higher Education Administration

Governors State University

University Park, Illinois 60484

2025

Acknowledgements

In the summer of 2005, I attended Junior Leader Training (JLT) as a sixteen-year-old. On my patrol flag, I signed my name as Dr. Blaise Lukasiewicz, putting the desire to one day have a doctorate into the world. Years later, after earning my Eagle Scout rank and working for Scouting America, I changed careers and ended up at Governors State University. After learning about the benefits of the position, I applied for the program and began to work toward my degree. Through the support of my wife and children, and the grace of God, I have made it to the end.

I thank my wife, Beth Lukasiewicz, for running the household and caring for the family when I needed to work on a paper. Thank you for lifting me when needed and reminding me that our daughters will have a better life because of this degree. You carried our youngest while I was studying and did not complain once when I needed to work on my paper despite needing a break.

Marian, Phillipa (Pippa), and Minerva (Minni) Lukasiewicz, thank you for giving me a hug when I needed it, for being a constant reminder that education is important, and for allowing me to show you that with determination and God, anything is possible.

Ginny-Marie, Steve, Andy, Noah (my siblings); Ginny, Steve, and Wiliam (parents); Robert, Peggy (in-laws); my extended family (too numerous to name); and friends (too numerous to name) thank you for allowing me to talk obsessively about my topic at length and listening to me, even if there was little interest in hearing it.

Thank you to the scouts that I have mentored now (Chris K.) and, in the past (Henry S., John S., Michael G., Brian R., Wyatt A., Emily B., and Jaimie C.), and the leaders that I lead with (Pat, Matt, Zach, Max, and more too numerous to name); you inspire me daily and make me

a better leader and person. You have taught me a lot about what it means to be a mentor and mentee. Thank you for allowing me to be your adviser and walk with you toward your goals.

I appreciate my cohort 10 peers and all my peers in the INLD program. I know I am a better leader, researcher, and colleague because of you all. Xochitl and Darryca, thank you for being there when I needed it, for making sure I did not feel alone at times, and for making me feel that we were in it together. Sandra, thank you for telling me what I needed to hear when I needed to hear it. I appreciate the sage wisdom and friendship. Cari, thank you for helping prevent me from throwing in the towel (there were a few times) and helping me stay optimistic through the writing blocks. Anne, thank you for being someone that I can always talk to.

I am beyond grateful for the supportive and welcoming INLD faculty who have helped guide me to this point. Thank you to my capstone chair, Dr. Matthew Cooney, who held me accountable and, at times, was a sympathetic ear. Thank you for encouraging me, giving me feedback (which is a gift), and helping me see the researcher I can be and am. Your dedication to ensuring that GovState graduates will be the finest practitioner-scholars is commendable, and the program is better with you. Many thanks to committee member Dr. Deborah King for helping me see that sometimes, when we stumble or things do not go our way, if we stop, then we have failed, so we must persevere. Thank you to committee member Dr. Jennifer Anderson for encouraging me to get involved in an academic journal, for your eleven years of friendship, for your encouraging words, and for allowing me the opportunity to mentor your son.

One last acknowledgment must be made, Mom, I am sorry that I did not turn out to be the priest in the family as you had hoped; I hope being a doctor will suffice.

Dedication

This capstone is dedicated to those on the scouting trail before me and those who will come after. I am grateful for the response from the Scouting Community and the Eagle Scouts who gave them time to share their feelings, thoughts, and ideas. The responses truly humble me, and their desire to help their communities inspires me.

This work is dedicated to my family. You have stood by this journey through the ups and downs. I am here because of you; your unwavering support, unconditional love, and pride in my work have made all the difficult times worth it.

I dedicate this work to my grandmothers, who taught me the value and importance of an education. From Grandma "Dearie" starting a college savings account for me, or Grandma Losos listening to me talk about my progress through my education, or calling me to tell me she was thinking about me. Without their guidance and love, I would not be the man I am today.

I dedicate this capstone to my fathers, Stephen V. Lukasiewicz and William R. Culp. Steve was the father who gave me life and taught me the value of Scouting and to love the outdoors. You taught me a lot in our short time together, and I know you are watching over me, keeping me safe. William, you are my father by choice, and you raised me during the difficult teenage years. Thank you for not giving up on me.

Last of all, I dedicate this capstone to first-generation college students. I am a first-generation college student, and to put it mildly, I had a rough go in my freshman year. This capstone proves that one year of college does not dictate your entire college career. What you do after you fall is what determines who you are.

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Eagle Scouts and the Contributing Factors to Civic Engagement on the College Campus

Abstract

The qualitative study followed a general inductive method to determine the influence the rank of Eagle Scout has on civic engagement among students in four-year public higher education institutions. The identified population for this research study was college-aged students who are currently enrolled or have attended public four-year higher education institutions. By exploring the experiences of Eagle Scouts in higher education settings, this research aimed to contribute to our understanding of how participation in the Scouting program and attainment of the Eagle Scout rank shape individuals' engagement in civic engagement activities during their college years. Previous research suggests that participation in Scouting programs can positively impact individuals' civic engagement. Jan et al. (2012) said Eagle Scouts are more likely to participate in civic activities than both non-scouts and scouts who have not attained the rank of Eagle Scout. This study found that Eagle Scouts tend to feel committed to and have a sense of duty to help their communities. They seek activities to improve their communities and "help other people at all times." These findings will inform educational institutions, youth organizations, and policymakers about the potential benefits and impacts of Scouting on students' civic engagement, providing insights that can help support and enhance the development of well-rounded individuals in higher education. The information gained has the potential to provide alternative options for student programming to ensure that students are ready to be civically minded and engaged when they become participating members of society.

KEYWORDS: *Eagle Scouts, Civic Engagement, Self-Efficacy.*

Eagle Scouts and the Contributing Factors to Civic Engagement on the College Campus
Chapter One: Introduction

Civic engagement and leadership development are two key outcomes of collegiate experience (Astin & Astin, 2000). Civic engagement and leadership development are important topics for higher education, and they were added as elective classifications by the Carnegie Foundation (American Council on Higher Education, 2024; Driscoll, 2008). Leadership development and civic engagement increase throughout the collegiate experience, and capacities for participation are strengthened through the student's time in college (McCarron et al., 2022). However, an individual's propensity for civic engagement activities can begin before their college experience. Participation in community-serving youth organizations can impact future participation in activities. One such organization that has been developing civically engaged citizens for over a century is the Boy Scouts of America, a scouting program, which was recently renamed Scouting America.

Participation in the scouting program provides students with experiences that will help shape their lives. Any experience can change direction and impact our path, the school a student will select to attend or not attend, or even what program to study. Participation in community-based youth organizations can change the trajectory of youth by using civic engagement and social integration (Wilmot, 2024). Experiences such as leadership skills and the perception of self-efficacy can impact how the student views the campus community and their part within it. Astin (1993) states in their seminal research that life can be viewed as a system with a series of inputs and outputs dictated by its environment. Viewing life from a systems theory perspective allows us to be critical of the system's inputs and the environment within which the system exists to determine the outcomes of the system. This environmental impact does not begin when the student enters college, but throughout their life.

After a student reaches higher education, there is a change in their environment as the role of education shifts. Primary education prepares students for learning later in life; secondary education allows students to think critically, ask more profound questions, and learn to collaborate (Mayhew et al., 2016). College allows students to continue to build upon what they learned in high school and prepare them for entering the job market. Another function of higher education institutions is to encourage students to participate in democratic activities (Patrick, 2022). These activities are necessary to ensure that the student population becomes participating citizens. Institutions must provide opportunities and support practices that will allow students to become effective citizens (Lizzio & Wilson, 2009). Prior experiences can impact involvement in such activities. Participation in civic engagement activities is not picked up overnight; these habits are picked up over time (Perrin & Gillis, 2019). Thus, participation in activities, both before and on campus, can impact the student's environment and change their path and outlook on their choices.

Context of the Problem

Civically engaged students and citizens are necessary to ensure democracy continues in the United States. However, the burden of promoting civic engagement and assisting youth transition into adulthood has been placed on the United States educational system (Albright et al., 2020). It will be necessary for higher education to understand better its role in producing more civically engaged students. This can result in the requirement of programming and understanding what, if anything, makes students more likely to participate in civic engagement activities.

Organizations such as Scouting America and other community-based youth-serving programs provide opportunities for youth to be exposed to civic engagement, which will

continue throughout their lives. Community-based youth-serving organizations help to develop the connection and relations between individuals and the world around them in their human development, known as Positive Youth Development (PYD) (Lerner, 2005). This issue is just as much for Scouting America as it is for society. Fewer youth participate in Scouting America programming, with just over one million scouts registered in 2024 (Scouting America, 2025b). A similar community-based youth-serving organization, Girl Scouts of America, has experienced similar issues with declining membership (Crary, 2021). Lack of participation—as apathy or anhedonia, is a concern for society.

Apathy is best known as the lack of enthusiasm or interest in a given topic (Robert & Manera, 2021). Anhedonia is commonly defined as the inability to experience pleasure or enjoyment from activities that would normally be pleasurable (Serretti, 2023). Not feeling pleasure in things concerns society. Having fewer youths who can connect to the world around them will hinder societal improvement and progress. Greater participation in the Scouting America program will create a greater societally focused citizenry, which will help society progress. Participation in community-based youth-serving organizations is not the only way to increase civic engagement.

The achievement of a four-year college degree has been found to correlate with political engagement (Burns et al., 2001; Hillygus, 2005; as cited in Perrin & Gillis, 2019); however, it is uncertain if higher education is responsible for the increased participation or if those who are more likely to be politically engaged also are the types to attend college (Perrin & Gillis, 2019). While civic engagement is not the same as political engagement, the two topics are related. Civic engagement encompasses three types of activities: community service, expressive, and political (Malin et al., 2017). Understanding what makes students more civically engaged and how their

prior experiences impact their civic engagement will help to create and develop programming to allow campuses to create more civically engaged students and, eventually, civically engaged citizens.

Curricular or high-impact experiences can impact participation in civic engagement activities during college (Perrin & Gillis, 2019). Civic engagement activities can provide additional benefits to the student and, as a result, the higher education institution. Participation in civic engagement activities can positively impact students' mental, physical, and social health and aid in the transition to campus life (Albright et al., 2020). Civic engagement activities significantly impact the campus's ability to impact the students and allow them to feel a part of the campus community and feel a sense of belonging. This will also aid in student retention and persistence efforts for the institution, again providing a benefit.

Purpose of the Study

This exploratory, descriptive qualitative research study explored Eagle Scouts' civic engagement among college students in four-year public higher education institutions. In exploring the experiences of Eagle Scouts in college or university settings, this research aimed to contribute to our understanding of how participation in the scouting program and attainment of the Eagle Scout rank shape individuals' engagement in community service and academic pursuits during their college years.

The exploratory descriptive style employed is best defined as a general inductive method, which provides the necessary background on the skills or perceptions that Eagle Scouts have regarding their civic engagement. Thus, a qualitative research methodology is viewed as the best approach given that it seeks to understand how an Eagle Scout feels and interpret their feelings on civic engagement. The general inductive or descriptive design approach allows for great

flexibility for the researcher to move from interview collection to examining themes, determining similarities amongst respondents, and determining shared meaning.

Framework of the Study

This section aims to examine the research foundations of *Student Involvement Theory* as it relates to the *Input-Environment-Outcomes (I-E-O) College Impact Model*. As students enter a higher education environment, they do not just enter college alone. Student experiences, prior learning, and even environments impact the students' frame of reference and shape them as individuals.

Student Involvement Theory

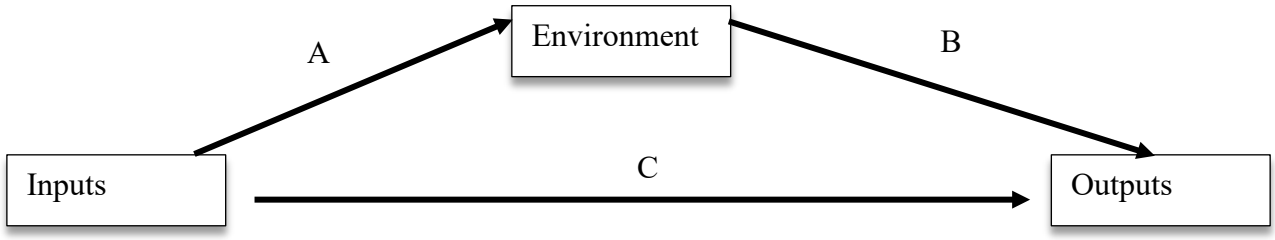
Astin's 1984 theory on student involvement assumes that the amount of student learning and personal development is proportional to the quality and quantity of the student's involvement in the program (Astin, 1999). This foundational theory is the root of our thinking in this study. If we know that student involvement is directly linked to student learning, we must determine what will indicate student involvement. Examining students' prior experiences will help shape our understanding of their involvement.

Input-Environment-Outcomes (I-E-O) College Impact Model

When examining how prior experiences impact students, Astin's (1993) input-environment-outcomes (I-E-O) college impact model is one of the more popular (Astin, 1999). This model can be used to examine previous experiences and how they relate to student outcomes in college (McCarron et al., 2022). The I-E-O College impact model can be viewed in Figure 1. Knowing what skills were developed prior to entering a higher education institution can help drive the development of programming to increase success in higher education institutions.

Figure 1

Astin's Input – Environment – Output College Impact Model (Astin, 1993)



To better understand how students are involved, researchers must also examine their self-efficacy. To build self-efficacy, one can take leadership coursework or have meaningful collegiate experiences (Dugan et al., 2011; Leupold et al., 2020). Leupold and colleagues (2020) affirm the notion that experiential activities drive self-efficacy more than a formal leadership development program. Perceived self-efficacy does not measure the number of skills you have, but "with what you believe you can do with what you have under a variety of circumstances" (Urdan, 2006, p. 342).

Self-efficacy has been found to be a powerful predictor of future action, even in new contexts (Urdan, 2006). Knowing how students perceive themselves is important to better understand how they see themselves in the classroom and their decisions. The interaction between the students' self-efficacy and their involvement as Eagle Scouts will help to understand how the program has impacted their self-efficacy and, in return, their confidence in participating in civic engagement activities.

Another area of study is civic engagement activities. These activities can fall into three main categories: political, expressive, or community service (Malin et al., 2017). Scouting America employs civic engagement activities to instill the values of the Scout Oath and Law. Scouting America encourages the unit's adult leadership to promote and encourage civic

engagement (Urban et al., 2022). Promoting civic engagement helps the Scout understand the importance of giving back and being a productive member of society.

Giving back creates a notion of civic purpose for the Scout, which Malin and colleagues (2017) define civic purpose

> as a sustained and engaged intention to contribute to the world beyond the self through civic or political action, is specifically a response to issues and concerns that lead to activity in the civic domain, such as through community service, responsible citizenship, or political action (p. 2).

Participation in these activities, while not directly related to the student's academic achievement, may have an impact. Besides being a well-rounded individual, these activities have the potential to help the student plan, accomplish a goal, and be a part of something larger than themselves (Malin et al., 2017). Students with these experiences can plan and achieve goals because of their participation.

Research Question

This descriptive qualitative research study is anchored in the following: How does achieving the rank of Eagle Scout influence involvement in civic engagement while enrolled in a four-year university? Descriptive is a word used to describe qualitative research because

> words and pictures rather than numbers are used to convey what was learned about a phenomenon (Merriam & Tisdale, 2016, p. 17).

How questions are valuable to the research process, because they can help determine the impact objects have on one another. How questions can also assist with determining the processes that must occur to obtain an alternate outcome. How questions, by their nature, are more open-ended, which assists the researcher in gaining more information about the phenomenon that is occurring.

Definition of Terms

This study seeks to explore the influence of attaining the rank of Eagle Scout on their involvement in civic engagement. As such, there are several key terms pertinent to the scope of this research. Below are several terms for review that will be used throughout the study.

Adults: Anyone over the age of 21.

Boy Scouts of America: The legal entity that operates Scouting America programs.

Civic Engagement: Activities that can fall into three main categories: political, expressive, and/or community service (Malin et al., 2017).

Crew: A grouping of Scouts aged 13-20 who decide on the unit structure, like a Troop.

Eagle Scout: An individual who has completed the following requirements: earned all the ranks in the Scouts BSA program in addition to earning 21 merit badges, 12 of which are Eagle required, held a leadership position in their scout troop, planned and implemented a community service project, and were evaluated on their practice and attitude toward the ideals of scouting by a board of review all of which are completed before the scout's eighteenth birthday (Jang et al., 2012).

Environment: "The student's actual experiences during the educational program" (Astin, 1993, p. 19).

Inputs: "Personal qualities the student brings initially to the education program" (Astin, 1993, p. 19).

NYLT: National Youth Leadership Training. A training program provided by Scouting America for their youth leaders.

Order of the Arrow: The honor society for Scouting America. Participants are inducted based on rank, camping nights, election, and participation in service activities.

Output: “The desired ‘talents’ that are being developed by the education program” (Astin, 1993, p. 19).

Patrol: A group of six to eight Scouts aged 11-18, usually organized by Scouting Rank or Age to work together as a unit and share responsibility. There are officially elected and unofficial positions in the patrol. Official positions include Patrol Leader, Assistant Patrol Leader, Patrol Quartermaster, and Patrol Scribe. The Patrol Leader reports to the Senior Patrol.

Scouting America: The rebrand of the Boy Scouts of America. It is a Doing Business As (DBA) for the Boy Scouts of America.

Scouts: Anyone participating in Scouting America programs can be a youth or an Adult.

Self-Efficacy: Confidence in oneself; belief that completing the task is attainable (Machida-Kosuga, 2017).

Senior Patrol: An elected group of Scouts, usually older, to oversee the Troop operations under the Scoutmaster's guidance. Members of the Senior Patrol include the Senior Patrol Leader, Assistant Senior Patrol Leader, Quartermaster, Scribe, Chaplain Aide, Historian, Instructor, Librarian, Webmaster, Order of the Arrow Representative, Outdoor Ethics Guide, Junior Assistant Scoutmaster, Bugler, and Den Chief.

Troop: A group of patrols, which are governed by a senior patrol, a patrol leaders’ council, a scoutmaster, and a troop committee.

Youth: Anyone under the age of 21.

Limitations

The research study employed a snowball sampling technique, which targeted representatives from a smaller group of individuals from the Scouting program in the Midwestern United States. The study's findings may not correlate with the experiences of all Eagle Scouts. In addition, while the Scouting program has the same requirements for the Eagle Scout rank, some requirements have options to be determined by the Scout.

For example, a Scout must earn the Swimming, Hiking, or Cycling merit badge. Each provides a different experience for the Scout and thus alters the Scout's perspective. In addition, how the program is executed varies from Troop to Troop. Therefore, completing the same requirements will give each Eagle Scout a vastly different experience.

Qualitative research provides a descriptive and contextual understanding of experiences and welcomes different perspectives; therefore, because the experiences of Scouts will be different, this study cannot be generalized amongst all Eagle Scouts (Johnson & Christenson, 2020). The sample size will naturally be smaller, function as a sub-set, as few scouts achieve the rank of Eagle Scout. This can be advantageous as it will allow for more in-depth interviews and discussions about the Eagle Scout's experiences.

Organization of the Proposed Study

This capstone project contains a total of five chapters. Chapter 1 covered background information, context of the problem, study purpose, framework of the study, and research questions. Chapter 2 provides a greater review of the theoretical framework that will be employed, including a literature review on civic engagement in higher education. Chapter 3 reviews the study's methodology and describes the population along with the data collection

procedures. Chapter 4 details the findings from this exploratory, descriptive qualitative research. Chapter 5 highlights the implications gleaned from the findings.

Summary

This research chronicles what causes Eagle Scouts to be more civically engaged than non-scouts. The selected frameworks showcase how the experience of becoming an Eagle Scout impacts a student's likelihood of participating in civic engagement by focusing on their experiences as an Eagle Scout. A background on the subject was provided, along with the context of the issue, the purpose of the study, and the research question. Basic definitions of key terms were provided, along with a description of how the study is organized. Chapter 2 will provide an in-depth literature review and theoretical frameworks for the study.

Chapter Two: Review of Literature/Theoretical Framing

The purpose of this exploratory, descriptive qualitative study was to examine the influence of achieving the rank of Eagle Scout on involvement in civic engagement among students in four-year public higher education institutions. This chapter provides the historical and scholarly context of Scouting America, the rank of Eagle Scout, and civic engagement. After covering the historical and scholarly context of the issue, the theoretical framework, specifically the use of Astin's (1999) Student Involvement Theories and Input-Environment-Output Model (1993), then the chapter will end with a synthesis of the existing literature.

Historical and Scholarly Context

Higher education has a rich history of promoting civic engagement, starting with the purpose of colonial colleges, which was to prepare individuals for positions within society (Geiger, 2015). Higher education institutions have a function to encourage their students to participate in democratic activities (Patrick, 2022); thus, it is part of the institutional makeup, just as learning is. Civic engagement activities fall into three distinct categories: political, expressive, or community service (Malin et al., 2017). Civic engagement is reinforced by education, but the development of lifelong civic engagement tends to be fostered in community-based youth organizations rather than extracurricular school activities (Kim et al., 2016). Community-based youth programming contributes significantly to participation in civic engagement activities later in life. These community-based youth-serving organizations or programs must ensure that they assist in the youths' development through participation in the program. This development through participation is known as the Positive Youth Development Framework (PYD).

The Positive Youth Development Framework (PYD) was developed to help give meaning to the adaptability of human development and the relations between individuals and the world

around them on their human development (Lerner, 2005). PYD asserts that "Community-based programs are a vital source of developmental assets (p. 29)," and it even mentions scouting as an organization that has positive development (Lerner, 2005). With Scouting being identified as a community-based youth-serving organization that uses the positive youth development framework, it is likely that participation in the Scouting America program will foster civic engagement among its members. Scouting America has been around for over 100 years and is one of America's premier youth leadership programs. The next section will chronicle a brief historical foundation of the Scouting America program.

History of Scouting America

Scouting for Boys was a movement founded by Lord Robert Baden-Powell in 1907 in London, England (Rohm & Osula, 2013). The movement was popularized by Baden-Powell's military success and the publishing of the book Aids to Scouting, the precursor book to *Scouting for Boys* (Arneil, 2010; Rohm & Osula, 2013). By 1910, Scouting came to the United States, and the first offices were opened in New York in a shared space in a YMCA office (Scouting America, 2009). In 1916, Scouting America received a Congressional Charter under Title 36 (Rohm & Osula, 2013). According to 36 USCS § 30902, the purpose of Scouting America is:

> to promote, through organization, and cooperation with other agencies, the ability of boys to do things for themselves and others, to train them in scoutcraft, and to teach them patriotism, courage, self-reliance, and kindred virtues using the methods that were in common use by boy scouts on June 15, 1916. (p. 7)

That is to make productive members of society. Scouting America is one of around 100 organizations to hold a Congressional Charter, and many that are chartered were done so because

they are “organizations with a patriotic, charitable, historical, educational, or other eleemosynary purpose…” (Moe, 2004, p. 4).

Scouting was created to fill a void and teach young boys outdoor skills, citizenship, and leadership (Arneil, 2010; Rohm & Osula, 2013). Scouting was not coed until 1969, when young women aged 14-20 could join special-interest Explorer posts (Scouting America, 2018a). It was expanded in 1971 to full membership, and the upper age limit was increased to 21 (Davies, 2023). While the mission was originally to teach boys, in 2019, Scouting America welcomed girls to their Cub Scouting program for youth aged six to eleven and rebranded the Boy Scout program to Scouts BSA for youth aged 11-18 (Scouting America, 2018b).

In 2024, they announced they would rebrand their name to Scouting America with no updates to the Scout Oath and Law (Scouting America, 2024a). This leadership and character development support the PYD framework. Lerner (2005) mentions that organizations that meet the PYD framework will use the “Five C’s” (p. 31) to meet the PYD framework: Competence, Confidence, Connection, Character, and Caring. Meeting the Five Cs means that the youth have a positive outcome due to their participation in the program. The Scouting program meets the Five Cs and, as a result, sustains positive characteristics later in life (Kim et al., 2016). The Five Cs can also be associated with civic engagement. Kim et al. (2016) found that the longer a scout is in the program, the more likely they are to have confidence and competence, which was significant in their study of civic engagement. Understanding that the Scouting program can influence civic engagement later in life is important and identifying the aims and methods used to achieve this is equally important.

It is important to note that the answer is not as simple as enrolling youth in the program to ensure civic engagement later in life. The impact of the activity and the benefits received vary

based on a few factors, such as the quality of the presentation of the programming and activity setting (Zarrett et al., 2021). This means that the adults who are involved in the Scouting program have a direct influence on the civic engagement of the youth later in life. Support provided to youth and trained leaders is imperative to the success of PYD activities (Kirchhoff et al., 2024). Kirchoff and colleagues (2024) suggest that mentorship and guidance be given to leaders to ensure the success of the activity. Mentorship is a beneficial way to support self-efficacy in individuals (Dunbar et al., 2018).

Today, Scouting America is headquartered in Irving, Texas, and is structured into 14 Council Service Territories (Scouting America, 2025a). These council service territories are made up of 241 local councils to support youth (Scouting America, 2025a). Scouting America issues charters to the 241 local councils, which in turn issue charters to the local chartered organizations (Scouting America, 2025b). Charter organizations partner with the local council to provide scouting programs in their community (Scouting America, 2025b).

These organizations agree to follow the policies of the national council and can include faith-based organizations, Parent Teacher Associations, civic clubs, or even businesses (Scouting America, 2025b). These organizations are permitted to select adult volunteers to run their scouting program (Scouting America, 2025b). This can make programming different depending on which organization your unit is associated with and can result in the same program being delivered differently.

Scouting America boasted over 1,071,389 registered youth (Scouting America, 2024c) and more than 628,000 adult volunteers (Scouting America, 2025b). These scouts provided 7.1 million hours of community service, which translates to a value of $225 million (Scouting America, 2024c). Scouting America operates four high adventure bases: Northern Tier in the

Boundary Waters of Minnesota; Summit Bechtel Reserve in West Virginia; Sea Base in the Florida Keys; and Philmont Scout Ranch in Cimarron, New Mexico (Scouting America, 2025b). Scouting America has awarded 2,383,158 Adventures and 1,314,421 Merit Badges in 2023 (Scouting America, 2024c). However, when it comes to scouting, the most well-known rank is Eagle Scout. Those who achieve the rank are in a small group. The next section provides a brief history of the Rank of Eagle Scout in Scouting America.

History of the Rank of Eagle Scout

The Eagle Scout award is the highest award in the Scouts BSA program, with the first award issued in 1912 (Jang et al., 2012; Polson, 2013). To achieve the rank of Eagle Scout, scouts must have achieved the ranks of Scout, Tenderfoot, Second Class, First Class, Star, and Life in addition to earning merit badges, holding leadership positions, and completing a community service project that impacts their community (Jang et al., 2012; Scouting America, 2024b). Scouts must also complete a Scoutmaster's Conference and sit before a Board of Review where the eagle candidate is evaluated on their "attitude and practice of the ideals of Scouting (Jang et al., 2012, p. 2)," all before their 18th birthday (Jang et al., 2012). Less than four percent of scouts will achieve the rank of Eagle Scout (Jang et al., 2012).

In recent years, the required merit badges may change, but ultimately, the purpose is the same: to ensure that the scout is prepared "to make ethical and moral choices over their lifetime (p. 2)" by following the Scout Oath and Law (Scouting America, 2025c). There are seven requirements in the Scouts BSA handbook (2022) for the rank of Eagle Scout, which are to

> be active in your troop for six months as a life scout; as a life scout demonstrate scout spirit; earn a total of 21 merit badges, including 14 eagle required; as a life scout serve in a position of responsibility in your troop; while a life scout plan, develop and give

> leadership to a community service project; while a life scout, participate in a Scoutmaster's conference; upon completion of all other requirements participate and complete a Board of review. (pp. 452-453)

The requirements, as they are found in the Scout Handbook, can be found in Appendix A.

Juggling extracurricular activities and high school coursework make the seven requirements challenging, making it difficult for some to finish on time. Wilmot (2024) found that it was more difficult to achieve the rank of Eagle without a support system at home. Support systems and family impact an individual's view of the world. This is why only about four percent reach the rank of Eagle Scout. With the leadership skills gained as an Eagle Scout in participating in their Eagle Project to support the community, it is likely that participation in civic engagement activities later in life will be greater. Unfortunately, there is little research on Scouts in College, but what is known is that Eagle Scouts are 30 percent more likely to have taken a course in the past year than Scouts and 80 percent more likely than non-scouts (Jang et al., 2012). The next section will outline the historical aspects of Civic Engagement.

Historical Considerations of Civic Engagement

There has been a decline in the levels of civic engagement over the past few decades (Procentese et al., 2023). The decline can partially be attributed to a lack of civic knowledge from increased testing mandates from No Child Left Behind (Raia, 2023). With a focus on instruction on academic skills and less of a focus on civic knowledge and engagement, society puts the burden of teaching civic skills and character development on community-based youth organizations (Zarrett et al., 2021).

This disadvantages youth, as the onus is shifted from society onto the family unit. This shift puts civic engagement in flux, meaning that some individuals have more knowledge than

others about civic engagement and their societal role. This leads to less collaboration and a decreased likelihood of interacting with neighbors (Polson et al., 2013). Polson and colleagues (2013) state that individuals who were heavily involved in scouting as youth were more likely to be connected to the community later in life. This will have a cyclical impact on future generations.

Upon entering college, students are given various unique opportunities to learn and grow. To aid in the facilitation of learning and growing, many college campuses have looked to civic engagement activities in addition to having meaningful college experiences. These experiences can be civic engagement activities, leadership development, or even mentoring experiences. These experiences can also be known as high-impact practices (HIPs) (Leupold et al., 2020). Steady increases in participation, both curricular and co-curricular, in experiential learning activities and HIPs in higher education as institutions realize the benefit of their use (Leupold et al., 2020).

These experiences are becoming more of a part of the educational landscape to ensure that students are getting the most out of their collegiate experience. HIPs have been found to have increased their academic skills in addition to aiding in their development (Leupold et al., 2020). HIPs are defined as learning experiences that go beyond the classroom, facilitate interaction with faculty and other students, demand great time and effort, facilitate collaboration with diverse individuals, and provide substantive feedback frequently (Leupold et al., 2020). Participation in these activities promotes civic engagement on campus and potentially later in life.

Scouting and HIPs are not the only ways for individuals to gain civic socialization and feelings about engagement activities. The family unit greatly impacts how the individual views

civic engagement. Civic attitudes are passed down from generation to generation, meaning if the older generations are participating, the younger generations are likely to follow in their footsteps (Body, 2022). Seeing older generations participating is imperative to the younger generation's adoption of civic engagement and is reinforced by participation in community-based youth organizations like Scouting America. The research objective will be outlined in the next section.

Theoretical Framework

This section examines the research foundation on Student Involvement Theory, as it relates to the Input-Environment-Outcomes (I-E-O) College impact model. In addition, the positive youth development (PYD) framework will be reviewed. As students enter the higher education environment, they do not just enter college alone. Student experiences, prior learning, and even environments impact the students' frame of reference and shape them as individuals.

Astin's Student Involvement Theory and I-E-O Model

Astin's 1984 theory on student involvement uses the assumption that the amount of student learning and personal development is proportional to the quality and quantity of the student's involvement in the program (Astin, 1999). This foundational theory is the root of our thinking in this study. If we know that student involvement is directly linked to student learning, then we must determine what will indicate student involvement. The level of involvement is directly related to the students' prior experiences. These prior experiences will be their foundation. Examining the prior experiences of students will help to shape our understanding of their involvement.

When examining how prior experiences impact students, Astin's (1993) input-environment-outcomes (I-E-O) college impact model is one of the more popular (Astin, 1999). This model can be used to examine previous experiences and how they relate to student

outcomes in college (McCarron et al., 2022). Knowing what skills were developed prior to entering higher education institutions can help drive the development of programming to increase success in higher education institutions. There is prolific literature on the I-E-O college impact model. Researchers have used as a basis for predicting radiography certification examination scores (Barymon, 2022), study outcomes of first year students (Chigbu et al, 2021), how input and environment influence developmental English student academic success (DeMonte, 2021), and even how learning characteristics and environment changed during the Covid-19 pandemic (Gui et al., 2023).

This model is well respected as a means of explaining how an environment impacts an outcome without discounting things that have happened previously. This model can help to understand how adjusting the environment for individuals will alter the outcome they experience (Kim & Kutscher, 2021). This model also makes assumptions about students. The I-E-O model assumes that the demographic characteristics that students enter college with will impact and affect their experiences on campus (Kim & Kutscher, 2021). In this model, you cannot change past inputs, but rather future inputs for the individual. In a subsequent study conducted by Astin, the I-E-O model was refined, and the new refined model found that the more engaged students are in learning, with all other things the same and input characteristics controlled for, the larger the learning outcomes attained (Gui et al., 2023). This shift will link learning outcomes, the educational environment, and the learner's integration and engagement in the said environment (Gui et al., 2023). This helps us to better understand how the environment influences growth.

The I-E-O model provides educational professionals with a method to provide meaning to how interventions impact outcomes (Wah Tan, et al., 2024). The Input for the study is the Rank of Eagle Scout; the environment would be a four-year college or university. The Outcome would

be how Eagle Scout, a four-year college or university, affects the student's participation in civic engagement activities. Using the interview data, we can determine if the environment had any impact on the likelihood of participating in civic engagement activities. In the Study, because we are examining the relationship between input, environment, and output, this model is best.

Self-Efficacy

Researchers must also examine their self-efficacy to better understand how students are involved. To build self-efficacy, one can take leadership coursework or have meaningful colligate experiences (Dugan et al., 2011; Leupold et al., 2020). Leupold and colleagues (2020) support the notion that experiential activities drive self-efficacy more than a formal leadership development program. Perceived self-efficacy does not measure "the number of skills you have, but with what you believe you can do with what you have under a variety of circumstances" (Urdan, 2006, p. 242). Problem-solving has been an indicator of high self-efficacy (Dunbar et al., 2018). Self-efficacy has been found to be a powerful predictor of future action, even in new contexts (Urdan, 2006). This is supported by Apesin and Gong's (2021) research, which says that if an individual has higher self-efficacy in high school, they tend to have higher self-efficacy in college as well. Knowing how students perceive themselves is important to better understand how they see themselves in and out of the classroom and the decisions they make.

Self-efficacy can be impacted by other variables. One such variable is the ability to think critically and self-awareness. Self-awareness and related self-reflection are important as they allow the student to reflect on their abilities and support their self-efficacy (Soria & Werner, 2018; Soria et al., 2019). This self-reflection is necessary to help the growth of the individual. Self-reflection can also give meaning to the experience and enhance their civic character (Syvertsen et al., 2024). The interaction between the student's self-efficacy and their involvement

as an Eagle Scout will help to understand how the program has impacted their self-efficacy and, in return, their confidence in their participation in civic engagement activities.

Civic Engagement

Civic engagement activities can fall into three main categories: political, expressive, or community service (Malin et al., 2017). This recalls the notion of civic purpose or as Malin and colleagues (2017) defined it

> as a sustained and engaged intention to contribute to the world beyond the self through civic or political action, is specifically a response to issues and concerns that lead to activity in the civic domain, such as through community service, responsible citizenship, or political action. (p. 1385)

Participation in these activities has other benefits, such as a positive correlation to academic achievement. Additionally, health benefits have been associated with participation (Jang et al., 2014). These benefits include long-term adoption of recreational lifestyles, with greater social capital, which in turn equals civic engagement later in life (Jang et al., 2014). Besides being a well-rounded individual, these activities have the potential to help the student plan, accomplish a goal, and be a part of something larger than themselves (Malin et al., 2017). Students with these experiences can plan and achieve goals because of their participation. Choosing to participate, however, can be influenced by internal and external factors, including peers (Trolian, 2019). In the next section, the Positive Youth Development Framework is chronicled.

Synthesis of Existing Literature

Upon reviewing the literature on the subject, a few themes were apparent: pre-college activities and civic engagement. These themes could then be broken down into subcategories. When all was said and done, it was apparent that the themes kept going back to how lived

experiences and participation in community-based youth organizations impacted participation in future civic engagement activities. These experiences, while unique for everyone, contributed to the makeup of who they are. Community-based youth organizations tend to meet outside the classroom, impacting the students most; however, it should be noted that some schools have organizations that support civic engagement as part of their extracurricular activity lineup.

For pre-college activities, there were some commonalities amongst the literature with topics such as self-efficacy and leadership development, parenting behavior, attitudes, and participation in activities. While not all-inclusive, these items provide a rich understanding of pre-college activities. Starting with self-efficacy, the research shows that to build self-efficacy, leadership coursework and meaningful colligate experiences are necessary (Dugan et al., 2011; Leupold et al., 2020).

Self-efficacy can determine future action (Urdan, 2006). Influential systems such as parents and social groups can also impact leadership development and self-efficacy (McCarron et al., 2022). The research also showed that participation in activities in college was driven by social perspectives that were obtained in pre-college experiences (Soria et al., 2018). This supports the notion and research that shows that participation in community-based youth programs can and will impact an individual later in life. One article by Davignon et al. (2023) goes against the majority of research, indicating that involvement in programming centered around pro-environmental behaviors had little impact on attitudes later in life, contrary to the majority of the literature. For our purposes, we will define self-efficacy as the confidence in the self to complete a task, which was adapted from Machida-Kosuga's (2017) study.

For civic engagement, more themes emerged from the literature and focused on the topics of participation, feeling a part of something bigger, cocurricular activities, psychological needs,

activities, and self-efficacy. It is important to note that pre-college activities drive self-efficacy and will allow individuals to participate in civic engagement activities. To better understand civic engagement, one must first understand what civic engagement is. A working definition of civic engagement can be found in Malin et al. (2017) as "activities that can fall into three main categories: political, expressive, or community service (p. 1385)." If the activity cannot fall into these three categories, it is not civic engagement. Political and community service activities are straightforward, but what are expressive activities? Expressive activities tend to be associated with political activities; an example would be contacting a representative or creating and using a protest sign (Malin et al., 2017).

Summary

This chapter provided a cross-section of the literature on the topics of civic engagement, the Scouting program, Astin's Student Development and Input-Environment-Output model, the Positive Youth Development Framework, self-efficacy, and pre-college activities. While there are many community-based youth organizations that can contribute to participation in civic engagement activities later in life, the Scouting program provides a robust offering for individuals starting in their Kindergarten year of school. Higher education institutions are responsible for creating and providing a more civically inclined, society-contributing citizen during school and post-graduation. The literature has shown that participation in PYD programming can impact civic engagement later in life. The next chapter will cover the methodology of the study.

Chapter Three: Methodology

This research study provides a greater understanding of the experiences of Eagle Scouts and their participation in civic engagement later in life. This chapter will explain what the study and the researcher have done and how the researcher conducted the research. To provide details, this chapter is organized into eight sections: Research Methodology, Research Design, Research Participants, Data Collection, Data Analysis, Trustworthiness, Positionality, and Ethical Considerations. Each of the eight sections will have subsections to provide additional information to support and explain the intention of this study. The chapter ends with a summary.

Research Methodology

The purpose of this qualitative study was to examine the influence of achieving the rank of Eagle Scout on involvement in civic engagement activities among students in four-year public higher education institutions. This research study employed an exploratory, descriptive qualitative method. Qualitative research collects narrative data, or rather data that is non-numerical in nature, which can be words, notes, full explanatory text, symbols, and or pictures (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). Qualitative research is often exploratory, interpretative, and focuses on making meaning from the phenomenon being researched (Johnson & Christensen, 2020; Merriam & Tisdale, 2016).

By exploring the experiences of Eagle Scouts in college or university settings, this research aimed to contribute to our understanding of how participation in the Scouting program and attainment of the Eagle Scout rank shape individuals' engagement in community service during their college years. The study will provide the necessary background on what skills or perceptions that Eagle Scouts have on their civic engagement. Thus, a descriptive qualitative method was viewed as the best approach, given that it seeks to understand how an Eagle Scout

feels about civic engagement. The general inductive method employs comparative content analysis alongside thematic review to examine themes, determine similarities amongst respondents, and determine shared meaning. The study aimed to answer the research question: How does achieving the rank of Eagle Scout influence involvement in civic engagement activities? In this chapter, the research design, participants of the study, including the criteria for involvement, as well as how the data will be collected, will be outlined.

Research Design

For this qualitative study, the research method employed was a general inductive method. A general inductive method is a procedure for the analysis of qualitative data that is guided by specific objectives (Thomas, 2006). Inductive approaches are less structured than some of the other methodologies that could have been employed. Inductive research allows for theories to emerge and allows for deductive analysis (Thomas, 2006). This provides the researcher with more freedom and flexibility when conducting research.

The exploratory nature of the study provided necessary data on a subject that has very little information, and the reflexive design provides an understanding of the impact that being an Eagle Scout has on civic engagement. An inductive approach was better than other qualitative research methods as it allowed us to understand how being an Eagle Scout influences a student's ability to participate in civic engagement activities without examining those who have not participated in the program. The inductive approach allowed the researcher to quickly interview participants and then move into the identification of themes in the text that relate to the objectives (Thomas, 2006). For this study, students who were involved in the scouting program and earned the Eagle Scout award are the cases that were examined. Prior to participating in the study, participants were funneled through a screening survey to determine their participation.

Screening Survey

An online self-reporting survey was the quickest way to determine eligibility. The survey included a few questions to determine the participants' eligibility. Questions were about the potential participants' credit hour attainment, age, if they were an Eagle Scout, and if they were currently or recently enrolled in a public four-year higher education institution. This information assists in determining if the potential participant is eligible to participate in the study. Data collected during the screening survey was only used to determine eligibility for participation. Questions regarding credit hours and university or college attendance were also asked during the semi-structured interview or focus group.

Research Participants

The inclusion criteria for the study consisted of college-aged Eagle Scouts, aged 18 and older, who have earned 30 credit hours and are currently attending or have attended a four-year public higher education institution. An Eagle Scout is someone who has earned all the ranks in the Scouts BSA program in addition to earning 21 merit badges, 12 of which are eagle required, held a leadership position in their scout troop, planned and implemented a community service project, and were evaluated on their practice and attitude toward the ideals of scouting by a board of review (Jang et al., 2012).

Verification of enrollment in a four-year public institution was completed by obtaining the Eagle Scout's campus email address. This allowed for a check to be done to ensure that it is indeed a four-year public higher education institution. Verification of obtaining the rank of Eagle Scout was done by affirming that they are an Eagle Scout on the screening survey and questions asked during the interview. Scouts subscribe to the values of the Scout Oath and Law, meaning that a Scout is Trustworthy, and thus their confirmation of the rank is satisfactory to verifying

achievement. Self-report was employed as the more pragmatic course of review. Participants also needed to have completed at least 30 credit hours. Once it was determined that they meet the eligibility criteria, an email was sent with further instructions to participate in the study. A copy of the eligibility email can be found in Appendix B. If a participant was determined not to be eligible for the study, an email regarding non-eligibility was sent. A copy of the email for non-eligibility can be found in Appendix C.

Sampling

Merriam and Tisdale (2016) affirm that qualitative research employs nonprobability sampling. Schoch (2020) mentions that the sample size for qualitative research studies is small, without giving a recommended specific size. In this study, purposeful sampling was used employing the criteria of Eagle Scouts, over the age of 18, who have 30 semester credit hours earned, and attend a four-year public university. It was possible that it could have been challenging to find individuals who met the criteria, resulting in a small number of participants. Yin (2003, p. 47) provides an explanation for the number of participants: if two to three are selected, this will be a simple replication; four to six might show different patterns; if six to ten all turn out as predicted, it would provide compelling support for the initial propositions. If the six to ten are contradictory, then the propositions should be examined, revised, and retested with a different set of cases (Yin, 2003). Having the data to support the initial proposition allows for rich narrative data and ample time for review.

To reach the sample size of six to ten participants, the study employed iterative convenience and snowball sampling techniques. Johnson and Christensen (2020) define convenience sampling as “including people who are available, volunteer, or can be easily recruited (p. 253.)” The author has a previous relationship with Scouting America that allowed

for the recruitment of recent Eagle Scouts who fulfill the criteria for participation; this recruitment was conducted via email sent to current Scoutmasters, Alumni Members, Order of the Arrow honor society members, Scouting America professional staff, and other Groups within the Chicagoland scouting community.

Snowball sampling was used after the convenience sampling; participants were asked to help identify other possible participants (Johnson & Christensen, 2020). This provided a wide network of potential participants. Participants were able to provide the potential participant's name and contact information upon conclusion of the first interview. The researcher then contacted potential participants.

Recruitment

Recruitment was conducted via two different means: social media posts, email, and direct email to suggested participants. The first method was social media; posts were submitted to Facebook and LinkedIn Groups. The first social media site is Facebook. The groups that were leveraged for recruitment are the Pathway to Adventure Council Mom's group, the BSA professional group, The Firm, and Eagle Scouts – Once an Eagle, Always an Eagle. On LinkedIn, the groups were BSA Alumni Educators, Scouting America, Eagle Scouts, and NESA-PTAC (National Eagle Scout Association Chapter). The social media posts can be found in Appendix D of this document. Posts were made by the author weekly during the timeframe of the study.

The second method was direct email to the staff of the *Pathway to Adventure Council (PATC)* to be sent out to recent Eagle Scouts. The email to the staff, along with an email to be distributed to the scouts, is found in Appendix E. Emails were sent to the Pathway to Adventure Council three times, providing a solid base for the study. The last method was a direct email to

individuals who were suggested to be participants based on criteria. The letter to potential participants can be found in Appendix F. Suggested individuals were emailed a total of three times every 30 days during the study or until they have completed their portion of the study.

Method of Data Collection

The data collection technique of semi-structured interviews was employed for this study. As mentioned previously, the study will begin with a screening survey to determine if the respondents qualify for inclusion. Once verified, respondents scheduled a semi-structured interview based on the availability of the participants.

Semi-Structured Interview

Merriam and Tisdale (2016) describe semi-structured interviews as gaining a first-person account of a certain event or experience. This provided data that helped determine if the rank of Eagle Scout influences involvement in civic engagement among college-aged students in four-year public higher education institutions. To qualify the participants, a survey was the best methodology for conducting self-reporting and qualifying candidates.

The survey took no more than two minutes to complete and contained questions (Appendix B) to provide contact information and qualify the participants for the study. The information recorded via the online survey was used to contact potential participants. While this survey is important to provide key information, it was not the study's primary data source.

Semi-structured interviews are “interviews that have questions that are more flexibly worded or have a mix of more or less structured questions” (Merriam & Tisdale, 2016, p. 110). Semi-structured interviews provide the researcher with some flexibility in the questions to facilitate the conversation. Using semi-structured interviews was paramount to understanding the impact earning the rank of Eagle Scout had on civic engagement. Attempting to coordinate

twenty participants could be a daunting task and difficult to achieve; individual semi-structured interviews were the best approach, as there was less to coordinate. Interview questions were developed in advance (Appendix C); however, based on responses from the participants, additional follow-up questions were elicited. Interviews were approximately 60 to 90 minutes, with most completed in 60 minutes, and there was the potential for two interview sessions with the participants.

The first interview was for the initial interview and gathering information. The interview was followed up electronically with a member check. Interviews were conducted via video conferencing software, Microsoft Teams, and were recorded to ensure the integrity of the data. Having interviews conducted via Microsoft Teams did not present any challenges, as Microsoft Teams has a recording built into the software. Interviewers followed specific guidelines to ensure that each interview was consistent (Appendix D). Informed consent was reviewed in the first interview; however, it was also sent out to the individual in advance to ensure they could review it and submit it electronically. Reviewing in person ensured that the participants understood and were willing to continue participating.

Data Analysis

After the interviews were completed and the recordings collected, the recordings were prepared for analysis. The first action item was to transcribe all the interviews. Interviews conducted using Microsoft Teams utilized the transcription feature, downloaded a copy of the transcripts in Microsoft Word, and were double-checked for accuracy. Data was kept in folders organized by individual participants. Data for the study was kept in the author's Microsoft OneDrive online for access and security. The researcher used third-party software Dedoose to assist with the analysis of the data. Respondents were labeled by their pseudonyms to ensure that

their identity was secure if the data were somehow accessed by someone who was not authorized. The researcher also checked with the university's Information Technology Services department to enable two-factor authentication for OneDrive to keep the data secure.

Coding of Initial Analysis

Upon transcription being completed, coding began. In Vivo coding was used; this is a process of providing a code label from the participant's own words (Jones et al., 2021). After the in vivo coding, axial coding was used to draw conclusions among codes (Jones et al., 2021). This allowed another level of analysis of the data and conclusions to be drawn. Once the coding was completed, a word cloud was created to view common words or phrases from the codes. Merriam and Tisdell (2016) recommend this visual presentation to illustrate the connections between concepts or categories. This was helpful in drawing initial conclusions, but ultimately did not provide the depth that was anticipated. The data was compared among participants to better understand and view shared experiences between participants. Upon conclusion of the initial analysis, the data was organized by how being an Eagle Scout affected their civic engagement.

It was examined and determined which traits came from the Scouting program and which traits came from outside Scouting. Qualitative research is often used to understand how experiences are interpreted (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). By examining how their experiences, being an Eagle Scout, impacted their civic engagement, we know just what aspects of Scouting support these two areas.

Trustworthiness

To ensure trustworthiness and research validity in the inductive study, three methods were employed to ensure that the data was valid and trustworthy. The first method that was employed

was the use of member checks or respondent validation. This allowed the respondent the ability to hear the preliminary findings from the study and provide them with the opportunity to clarify any information that may have been misunderstood by the researcher (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). This ensured that there was no misunderstanding and confirmed with participants that the analysis conducted was true. It removed any doubt from the researcher.

The second method that was employed to ensure validity and trustworthiness was reflected in the researcher's positionality. The researcher's position provided a background on how the researcher was affected by the research process, any biases, dispositions, or assumptions (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). This was already included in this study and provides the researcher's values on how they are related to the topic.

Peer Debriefings

The third method that was employed to ensure validity and trustworthiness was peer examination. The peer review process is one where the researcher's peers will read and comment on the findings of the study (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). The study being conducted was for a doctoral capstone. As a result, there were three individuals who reviewed the paper and provided feedback on it. The peer review committee all have doctorates. The first peer reviewer holds a PhD in Higher Education, Higher Education Administration. The second peer reviewer holds a PhD in Social Work. The third peer reviewer holds a PhD in Language, Literacy, and Sociocultural Studies. Between the three, there was a wide spectrum of knowledge and expertise that ensured the qualitative general inductive method used in the study met the educational rigor that should be expected. Data was shared with peer reviewers via file sharing on OneDrive by request. They were only able to view and provide feedback on the materials shared; however, they were not able to share them with others.

Positionality

Jones et al. (2021) discussed the notion that the researcher is an instrument in qualitative research. I am a proud Eagle Scout who earned the rank in 2007. My brother is an Eagle Scout, in addition to several of my close friends, and even my late father is an Eagle Scout. I grew up in a Scouting family, and my parents believed that the values of the Scout Oath and Law were the values instilled in me by the scouting program. In addition, I am a first-generation college student who struggled during my first year of college, not realizing that there were skills learned through scouts that would ultimately help me achieve my academic goals. During my first year of college, I became involved in the campus resident hall council and resident hall association to ensure my voice was heard. I also had the opportunity to volunteer with a scout troop in Charleston, IL, to help impart my knowledge to other scouts.

I am very familiar with interviews and surveys, having created many surveys and conducted interviews throughout my college career. While attending Moraine Valley Community College, I was a reporter for the paper and collected information from eyewitnesses. In a recent class, I interviewed a community college president on strategic planning. As for surveys, I have experience creating surveys. Surveys were conducted multiple times in my undergraduate and professional experiences.

I am currently volunteering with the Pathway to Adventure Council, Scouting America, where I mentor youth in the program. I currently serve as the Cubmaster of Pack 341 in Oak Forest, IL, my daughter's Cub Scout Pack. I have received Eagle Scout mentor pins from three scouts based on my advice and counsel during work on their Eagle Project. I previously worked for the Boy Scouts of America, specifically the Pathway to Adventure, Calumet, and Chicago Area Councils. My rich and robust personal and professional experiences add to the credibility of

the proposed research project. Credibility in qualitative research is when the reader is informed of the research process (Saldana, 2011). Credibility in qualitative research is thus achieved by citation of similar works in the literature review and citation of seminal authors, as well as through the specified data analysis that is employed (Saldana, 2011).

I also serve as an Adviser in the local Council's Chapter of the National Camping Honor Society, or the Order of the Arrow. I am an insider in the program and have witnessed first-hand the growth of youth into adult leaders as well as the role Scouting has in creating more civically engaged citizens. My role with the national honor society chapter provides me with the opportunity to interact with college-aged scouts. Many of these scouts, however, go away to school rather than commute to school. These interactions can assist me in finding participants for the study. This does mean that I do look more fondly at the scouting program, which may result in framing results in a more favorable light. Understanding this can help prevent that from occurring.

Ethical Considerations

During the study, steps were taken to ensure that the research was conducted ethically and that the participants were protected. Much of the study was conducted online, which means that additional ethical considerations must be considered (Merriam & Tisdale, 2017). College campuses are looking for a more civically engaged student body, which will in turn create a more civically engaged populace. Using a general inductive method was the best method as it allowed for flexibility to examine how being an Eagle Scout truly impacts their civic engagement on campus. This research provides a deeper understanding of what, if anything, from the Scouting program can be used to create a custom program for Colleges or Universities to assist with creating more civically engaged students.

Institutional Review Board Statement

Prior to beginning the research study, approval was obtained from Governors State University's Institutional Review Board. Information regarding the study was sent to the board for review. Prior to the study going before the Institutional Review Board, the content was reviewed by the Chair of the Dissertation Committee and the Assistant Director of Research Compliance. The study was then approved, and recruitment of participants could begin. During the study, neither the participant nor the author received compensation for their participation. Participants only received the knowledge that they assisted a fellow scout with the completion of their college degree. No financial compensation was offered.

Participants' identities were kept anonymous and not shared with anyone. Data from the research was kept on the author's OneDrive in an encrypted folder that used multifactor authentication to ensure access was only obtained with the knowledge of the author. This ensured that the data was kept secure and private. Prior to participation, potential participants received a digital copy of the informed consent document. A digital signature was obtained by the researcher before asking any questions. A participant could choose not to answer a question or withdraw their consent at any time. During the first portion of the interview, it was reviewed to ensure that participants understood. During the study, the capstone chair provided ethical advice to the author when needed.

Summary

This descriptive qualitative research study provided an opportunity to understand how being an Eagle Scout impacts students' civic engagement on their college campus. In this chapter, the author reviewed the methodology of research design and its importance. Then, the chapter reviewed who qualified to be a research participant as well as how they were going to be

recruited for the study. Then the chapter reviewed the data collection methods, how the data would be collected, where the data would be stored, and how it would be coded. Finally, the chapter concluded with the validity, reliability, and trustworthiness of the study and how the author fits into the study.

Chapter Four: Findings

The purpose of this qualitative study was to examine the influence of achieving the rank of Eagle Scout on involvement in civic engagement activities among students in four-year public higher education institutions. This research study employed a qualitative research method. The research question that guided the study was: How does achieving the rank of Eagle Scout influence involvement in civic engagement while enrolled in a four-year university?

The research study focused on the understanding of Eagle Scouts' lived experiences based on their involvement in the Scouting Program (Inputs), their college experience (Environments), and their involvement in Civic Engagement activities in College (Outputs) (Astin, 1991). The questions were based on the three aspects of the theoretical framework of Astin's (1993) I-E-O model (inputs, environment, outputs). The research study revealed three major themes: (a) influences on civic engagement; (b) college's impact on civic engagement; and (c) civic engagement today, tomorrow, and in the future.

The research study discussed their civic engagement experiences prior to entering college and after enrolling in a four-year public institution. The results shared insight into the shared experiences, how they interacted with their college environment, and their desire to continue to be civically engaged in the future. This chapter provides the demographics of the interviewed Eagle Scouts, a profile of the Eagle Scout, and a summary of the findings of the semi-structured interview.

Participants

The participants in this study obtained the rank of Eagle Scout and are currently enrolled in a four-year degree program. Participants consisted of both men and women with a majority from the Midwest. The participants are listed in Table 1.

Table 1

Eagle Scout Demographic Information

Eagle Scout	Gender	Age	Ethnicity	Eagle Scout Rank Date	Credits Earned
Adrian	Man	21	White	2019	101
Ambrose	Man	18	White	November 2023	33
Craig	Man	18	White	October 2023	85
Derek	Man	18	White	November 2024	62
Edmund	Man	20	White	December 2020	100
Elijah	Man	19	White	2023	36
Isla	Woman	21	White	October 2020	109
Julian	Man	19	White	May 2022	65
Liam	Man	22	Whiate	December 2020	159
Lucas	Man	18	White	August 2022	61
Marcus	Man	22	White	January 2019	122
Morgan	Woman	21	White	2021	70
Sienna	Woman	21	White	March 2022	84
Sophia	Woman	23	White	February 2021	130

In addition to the demographics table, an interpretive profile for each participant was completed. These profiles were a snapshot of the participants; the profiles provided a greater holistic view of the participants, integrating demographic data and interview responses and observations. These profiles provided a summary of the participants, based on what the researcher gained from the interview and the interpretation of the researcher's findings. These profiles allowed the participant to reflect on the interview, interpretations of the participant's experiences, and ensure that their responses were accurate

Adrian

Adrian is a college senior at Indiana University Indianapolis, pursuing a computer science degree with a minor in mathematics. Adrian is a 21-year-old male who grew up in a middle-class family in Northwest Indiana. Adrian says this about himself:

> Outside of school and Scouts, I was not expecting that [question], cause school is literally what takes up all of my time. But, I enjoy photography, I love studying computer science, I know that school-related, but so is a lot of what I do. Right now, I'm just getting back into reading for fun. I'd love to pick up a good book and just read in my bed or something, just for fun. It's a really relaxing, enjoyable, and better than scrolling endlessly online.

Adrian earned the rank of Eagle Scout in 2019, after completing his project designing and implementing a composting center in his middle school to address food waste sustainability, cutting down on landfill accumulation. The scouting program provided Adrian with transformative experiences that broadened his worldview. Adrian lives and breathes the scout motto of "Be Prepared" daily, incorporating plans for the unexpected that may occur in his life into his daily routines.

When it comes to civic engagement, Adrian believes that everyone has a "moral obligation to try to make the world a little bit of a better place than they found it." Adrian continues to volunteer, racking up between 20-30 hours per year. Adrian attributes his participation in civic engagement activities to the positive influence of different Scout Masters and Adult Advisers who supported him and encouraged him to continue to go forward and take on new opportunities. These mentors did not mandate the service but explained the "why you should" be engaged, providing the foundation for lifelong civic engagement. Adrian finds himself applying lessons learned from his scouting mentors, hearing the voices of former leaders guiding him in his approach. Adrian recognizes that there is not a one-size-fits-all approach to community service and civic engagement. He finds that circumstances and capabilities should drive a person's desire to stay involved in their community. Adrian's participation in the scouting

program has allowed him to participate in civic engagement and has set the foundation for participation for years to come.

Ambrose

Ambrose just completed his freshman year at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign. He is working towards completing a double major in psychology and communication with plans to add a leadership studies minor. Ambrose is 18 years old and grew up in a middle-class family in the southwestern suburbs of Chicago. Ambrose said:

> I did running for a bit, but I stopped running this year, but like I ran in 1/2 half-marathon last year. I play a lot of video games with friends. I try to be very active with my friends in general. I do service outside of scouting, and I've helped out on various farms. Just doing some service there, and then I try to help out a lot with my high school right now, like I come back. I helped them find a stage for their performance for their winter performance. 'Cause the place they usually use canceled on them, and then I've done a lot of like fixing things and stuff at my high school as well.

Ambrose is also attempting to visit every fast-food restaurant in a specific chain in America and charts his visits on social media. Ambrose earned the rank of Eagle Scout in 2023, after completing his project of repairing livestock fences at his school's farm to help keep, specifically, the school's donkey from escaping. Ambrose gained much from the scouting program but took to heart the notion of "those who chose us need us" and feels it is his duty to continue to give back wherever he can.

When it comes to civic engagement, Ambrose has become involved on his campus, serving on the Liberal Arts and Sciences First Year Experience Advisory Board. He believes that civic engagement is essential: *"*If you believe in something, you should stand up for it*,"*

acknowledging that at times he only does the bare minimum. Ambrose is aware of some of the community issues facing the Urbana-Champaign area but has not found opportunities to support those causes and aid the community. While graduation is far away for Ambrose, he expressed intentions on staying connected to the community in which he lives, suggesting a strong foundation of civic engagement in the future.

Craig

"So, outside of Scouting, I am attending the University of Illinois, Urbana-Champaign. I am studying astrophysics. I'm going into my sophomore year." Craig just completed his freshman year at the University of Illinois Urbana-Champaign. He is an astrophysics major. Craig is 18 years old and grew up in a middle-class family in the northwestern suburbs of Chicago.

> I am involved in a few different student organizations. I am a general member of the Astronomical Society, and I am also the philanthropy chair for the Outdoor Adventure Club on campus. In high school, I played percussion and I was in marching band along with scouting, and then in college, I've been focusing more on like my studies. I have been in this last year, I've been able to get on a research project, and like some instrumentation stuff for astrophysics, and yeah.

The research projects that Craig works on were in partnership with NASA. Craig obtained the rank of Eagle Scout in 2023 after working with a local forest preserve district to build a 2/3-mile trail. Craig credits scouting with developing his integrity and timeliness, which helps him academically.

Craig's approach to civic engagement has been one of "pay it forward." Craig feels that individuals should participate in civic engagement activities to benefit the community rather than

for personal gain. Craig spent time participating in the Order of the Arrow High Adventure (OAHA) programs. OAHA participants spend their time doing service work such as rebuilding, building or repairing trails, portages, and other services at the four High Adventure bases. He notes that "other scouts" and "leaders" encouraged him to "get involved" and provided "resources" to pursue service opportunities. This supportive environment created expectations for community involvement that extended beyond scouting activities.

Derek

Derek is an 18-year-old student who is pursuing electrical engineering at SUNY Maritime College. Derek grew up in a family where a master's degree is the highest level of education. Derek grew up in New York. "OK, so, outside of scouting, I did baseball for a while when I was growing up. Nowadays, out in schools mostly all I do. Recently, I started working at a local cemetery."

In 2024, Derek achieved the rank of Eagle Scout after building a drainage system and rebuilding a train for his local school. Derek has a strong civic foundation rooted in his scouting experience and family influence, though college has created barriers to active participation. He demonstrates mature thinking about civic responsibility and maintains thoughtful news consumption habits while avoiding social media for political discourse. His ongoing heavy involvement in scouting through the Order of the Arrow continues to shape his civic development even in college. Derek believes that to participate meaningfully in society, one must be civically engaged.

Derek is willing to do what is right for those around him, despite the feeling that doing the right thing will not go anywhere. When looking at Derek, it is apparent that the college environment can serve as a bridge for civic engagement, building on past values and creating a greater, more sophisticated understanding of civic processes. Derek is involved in an "Eagle

Scout Fraternity" on campus, which runs an annual camporee. Derek represents a civically conscious young adult whose engagement has been significantly shaped by his scouting experience. While currently limited by college logistics, he demonstrates strong foundational civic values, informed news consumption habits, and clear intentions for future community involvement. His approach to civic engagement appears measured and thoughtful, prioritizing meaningful participation over performative activism, with scouting serving as both the catalyst and ongoing framework for his civic development.

Edmund

Edmund, a 20-year-old, completed his junior year at Illinois State University. He earned his Eagle Scout Rank in December of 2020 after designing, building, and delivering firewood storage boxes for a YMCA camp in Wisconsin. Edmund grew up in a middle-class family but described his home life as being "semi-rough." Edmund lived in the northwest suburbs of Chicago. The scouting program provided Edmund with an outlet to have meaningful experiences with supportive and caring adults.

> Oh man, there's not a lot. I'm super, super active in my church, and so that kind of fills up the rest of my time. So, my main… I would say engagement outside of scouting is stuff like that. I lead a men's small group at my church, and that's really it.

Edmund credits his time in scouting for shaping his time management skills, calendar planning, and his work ethic. He completes tasks without complaint, with the knowledge that some work does not provide immediate personal gain.

Edmund believes that civic engagement falls into different levels of engagement, from those who only vote, those who are socially engaged but avoid politics, and those who are politically focused rather than socially focused. He feels that well-rounded citizens are a

combination of socially engaged and politically focused individuals. It is Edmund's belief that civic engagement is the fundamental responsibility of all citizens, and it is the foundation of democratic governance. Edmund has transitioned from scout-facilitated civic participation to independent community leadership, demonstrating the long-term impact of the scouting program on civic development.

Elijah

Elijah is a 19-year-old college student enrolled at Colorado Mesa University, studying outdoor recreation. He grew up in Colorado. The highest educational level of his parents is a master's degree. Elijah earned his Eagle Scout award in 2023 after constructing a new 12-foot-tall challenge wall for a high ropes facility course for his school. The challenge wall was designed to enhance team connectivity for those using the facility. Elijah stated that his work ethic developed while working on his Eagle project continues to benefit him academically, applying the same persistence and planning to his college coursework. The Scouting program has also provided him with a civic engagement foundation that he carries with him to this day.

> I'm a part of Kappa Sigma fraternity. I do a lot of stuff with them. I'm, like, social media chair. I do a lot of, like, photography and all that. I'm studying outdoor recreation, just like being outside, hiking, all that.

Elijah's sense of civic responsibility stems primarily from his scouting experience, particularly the influence of his Scout Master as a role model. He feels obligated to give back to his troop, neighborhood, and family, who have supported him throughout his life. Since entering college, this has shifted slightly for Elijah; school pressures have made it more difficult to participate, but his involvement in his Fraternity has created opportunities for service to keep him engaged. In

the future, Elijah hopes to remain civically engaged in areas that are related to his career interests.

Isla

Isla is a 21-year-old college student attending the University of Iowa. Isla grew up in a western suburb of Chicago. Her mother earned a high school diploma, and her father has a bachelor's degree. Isla earned the rank of Eagle Scout in 2020 after creating a memorial serenity garden in her hometown. The project included creating benches, planters, and installing a sundial, making regular greenspace into an area of reflection.

> Outside of scouting in school, I do a lot of just outside activities. I like to be outdoors. I like to go on vacations a lot and just travel to new places. I think I had three vacations last year, and I have at least two coming up in the summer, so I'm excited for those, especially since I don't have to worry about work or homework. And then I just like to spend a lot of time with family and friends. I feel like whenever I come home, I'm never actually resting. I'm jumping between each family member's house, which is convenient that they sort of live in the area, but also just never get a break in time. But that's still fun to catch up with everyone, and especially see people that I'm close with.

When Isla joined scouting, she found that some community members were critical and skeptical of her involvement, but inside the program, she found nothing but overwhelming support. Isla found that one of the main things that scouting taught her was her time management skills.

Isla's civic responsibility stems from her Catholic educational environment and her family values, emphasizing service to others. Isla defines civic engagement as actively participating within communities through various forms of contribution - time, knowledge, or skills. She views it as essential for establishing roots and finding belonging, particularly

important as a college student away from home. Scouting profoundly shaped Isla's civic attitudes and capabilities. The program introduced her to diverse volunteer opportunities she would not have discovered otherwise and provided structured pathways for community engagement. Despite current constraints, Isla remains committed to lifelong civic engagement. She plans to re-establish community roots after college through service activities, continued religious community involvement, and ongoing participation in scouting as an adult leader.

Julian

Julian is a college student at Ohio State University studying public management, leadership, and policy. Julian is 19 years old and is part of a middle-class family. In 2022, Julian obtained the rank of Eagle Scout after coordinating the building of benches, a gravel sitting area, and a fire pit at his local church.

> Aside from scouting in school, sure, I work at a corner store. In a small town, it's kind of nice because I feel like a local celebrity sometimes, cause everybody knows who I am, because almost everyone in the town goes through me. I have two sisters, one older, one younger. And then I have both my parents. I enjoy rain shooting, so you know, going to the range, that's a nice hobby, whether that's archery or guns.

Julian uses the time management skills that scouting has taught him to ensure that he is successful academically. He also stated that he was “allowed to mess up” in scouting, which proved to be invaluable to his personal development.

Julian understands that civic engagement is more than just helping others; living in an economically disadvantaged area, he knows that “when someone’s walking around with a smile on their face, it goes a long way.” He feels that civic responsibility is rooted in reciprocity and intergenerational obligation. “Someone else did it for me, so I should do it for the next guy.” This

notion shows Julian's feeling that civic engagement is a universal responsibility for all citizens. Julian has found that sometimes civic engagement is harder in college because you may encounter peers who "don't find that enjoyable" or actively undermine civic efforts. His overall experience shows that a strong pre-collegiate civic foundation can persist through challenging college environments.

Liam

Liam is a 22-year-old who graduated from Miami University of Ohio with a degree in political science and international studies. Liam grew up in a northwest suburb of Chicago in a middle-class family. In 2020, Liam achieved the rank of Eagle Scout after mulching the playground and repainting the religious school entrance at his synagogue. Outside of school, Liam was very involved in Jewish campus organizations and worked on political campaigns. "I am a recent college graduate. I graduated in January of this year [2025]. I spend my time job searching and interviewing for jobs." Currently graduating with a degree, Liam is navigating post-college life, working on obtaining a position in the public sector. He credits the scouting program for instilling in him the appreciation of "doing something for someone greater than myself."

Liam really got the experience of being civically engaged, working on a congressional campaign in 2020. His civic engagement continued on campus when he joined Alpha Phi Omega and continued his work on community service projects. His approach to service work reflected scouting values, particularly his willingness to tackle unpleasant tasks that others avoided, such as retrieving trash from difficult locations. Liam also hopes to continue to be able to have political discussions with others to provide a greater understanding of opposing viewpoints.

Lucas

Lucas is an 18-year-old studying History as his major coursework with a minor in military studies at Illinois State University. Lucas grew up in the western suburbs of Chicago in a family where both of his parents obtained master's degrees. In 2022, at the age of 15, Lucas earned the rank of Eagle Scout after renovating a multipurpose community space in his former church. The project included deep cleaning, painting, and refinishing the archery targets that the church used for their summer camp program. Lucas does not have a lot of free time, as he is an active member of Illinois State University's Reserve Officers' Training Corps (ROTC).

> Yeah. So, out of school and scouting, I am the kid in the Army ROTC program at Illinois State. So, I spend time working out, getting ready to be an Army officer. In addition, I'm on the Fencing and Water Polo Club teams at ISU. And then yeah, I don't have a lot of spare time, so I'm asleep for most of it, 'cause I have to get up really early. Yeah, I like my sleep these days.

He credits scouting with teaching him essential skills, including leadership, public speaking, and the importance of hard work and persistence. The experience significantly impacted his academic approach, helping him develop a "knuckle down and get it done" mentality that serves him well in managing college workloads.

Lucas views civic engagement as highly important to quality of life and community connection, though he believes it should be a personal choice rather than a strict obligation for all citizens. He credits specific scouting mentors, particularly his first and second Scoutmasters (one who was a lobbyist who became his neighbor), with instilling the importance of civic participation and community engagement. The interview reveals Lucas's evolution into a mentor role himself, as he now provides guidance to younger scouts and high school students. He

recognizes that people increasingly turn to him for advice and leadership, which he attributes partly to the reputation and capabilities associated with being an Eagle Scout. Lucas is currently exploring a transition from his Methodist upbringing to Catholicism, largely influenced by his positive experiences with the Newman Center and Knights of Columbus on campus.

Marcus

Marcus is a 22-year-old male who grew up in a middle-class family; both of his parents earned master's degrees. He is a recent graduate of Christopher Newport University with a degree in business management. In 2019, Marcus earned the rank of Eagle Scout, and his project was to replace deteriorated railings on a 45-foot footbridge used by his high school's cross-country team.

> I'm Episcopalian. I enjoy doing volunteer work and giving back to others, and honestly, that's reflected a lot in both my school and my scouting career as well. I'm still active in scouting. And, I really enjoy movies, and TV shows, and games that have that mindset of giving back in some way. Whether that is, like, through super heroics or through community service.

He believes that it is his purpose to help others, and he does this through volunteer work with various campus organizations.

Marcus worked on campus as a Resident Assistant and finally as a Senior Resident Assistant during his senior year. He graduated with a service distinction leader cord for completing over 400 hours of community service during college. Marcus enjoys working with first-year students in the peer mentoring program to get the students off academic probation. Marcus plans to pursue a career in residence life and student affairs in higher education, viewing this as his primary avenue for civic impact. He recognizes that while he may not make

groundbreaking discoveries or achieve historic prominence, he can create safe environments where others can flourish and potentially achieve great things. This philosophy reflects the mentoring approach he learned through scouting. Overall, Marcus does struggle with the balance of personal conviction against his leadership roles with various organizations, which influences how he expresses himself publicly.

Morgan

Morgan is a 21-year-old female from the northwestern suburbs of Chicago. Her family's highest education level is a master's degree. Morgan attends the University of Wisconsin-Whitewater, studying marine biology with a minor in finance. She had some difficulty adapting to college and attended Harper College and McHenry County College before moving on to UWW. In 2021, Morgan achieved the rank of Eagle Scout, the first female from her service territory and troop. For her Eagle Scout project, Morgan collected T-shirts and personal care items to create reusable bags for those with housing insecurities.

> I'm very big in my religious group at my church. I work at a local Red Robin as a server in multiple different positions. I help in any local community groups, whether it be, just even just picking up trash and all that around the neighborhood and all that.

She also enjoys talking with her neighbors and helping her local community with cleanups and other projects.

Morgan defines civic engagement as giving back to the community and helping wherever needed, maintaining a "yes" mindset without bounds to her ability. However, she rates the importance of civic engagement to herself as "in the middle," acknowledging that while people should want to participate, not everyone has the willingness or ability to do so. She does not view civic engagement as a universal responsibility for all citizens. Morgan maintains a

deliberately neutral stance on political matters, not wanting to rock the boat. She has never voted in a political election. Her approach emphasizes practical, direct service over political activism, reflecting a civic engagement style rooted in personal relationships and tangible community impact.

Sienna

Sienna is a 21-year-old female student studying Speech Language and Hearing Sciences at Purdue University – West Lafayette. Sienna grew up in a lower-middle-class family where both of her parents had earned college degrees in Lake County, Indiana. She earned the rank of Eagle Scout in 2022 after completing her Eagle Scout project working with "Buddy Bags," a community program providing food and school supplies to less fortunate individuals. She built shelving units for the organization and established a "Give a book, Take a book" literacy program.

> So, oh, also outside of school, I am majoring in speech, language, and hearing sciences. However, outside of school, I participate in extracurriculars such as the National Speech, Swallowing, Language, and Hearing Association as a liaison intern for ISHA, which is the Illinois Speech and Hearing Association. On top of that, I am a supervisor for the freshman orientation program at Purdue University called Boiler Gold Rush, which is very similar to the program NYLT, but it is just for freshmen of college, which I think is pretty awesome.

She considers civic engagement very important and believes it is the responsibility of all citizens to understand their government and country. She views herself as an active citizen, citing her voting behavior, participation in nonprofit events, consumption of factual government information, and community involvement. Sienna maintains civic engagement despite academic

demands, though she acknowledges junior year made participation more challenging. She's particularly interested in long-term support for causes related to education, women's rights, and medical research. Her career aspirations include law school and potentially running for political office, expressing enthusiasm about contributing to governance. Her experience suggests that scouting's influence on civic engagement extends beyond immediate program participation into lifelong patterns of community involvement and democratic participation.

Sophia

Sophia is a 23-year-old female college student who is pursuing a master's degree in social work from Michigan State University. She completed her undergraduate degree at Grand Valley State University. She is a first-generation college student who grew up in the southwestern suburbs of Chicago. Sophia earned her Eagle Scout award in 2021, being a part of the inaugural class of female Eagle Scouts. Her project was building an ADA-compliant Gaga ball pit for her local park district so individuals of all ability levels could enjoy the game or use it as a sandpit or ball pit.

> Oh man, it's always scouting in school. I feel like I talk about it. I am very into the outdoors except for school, and that lately has looked like a lot of kind of. What can I do to be more sustainable - within my consumption of things. And so, I have gotten it really into learning more about sustainable gardening and kind of like cooking from scratch. Those have been my hobbies. I like it too. To cook and sew and such, I'm a granny. What else do I like to do outside of school? I love to get outside, like, biking too. That's very fun. I participate in my church. Does that cover, or are we looking for something else? I'm pretty boring.

Scouting has significantly influenced Sophia's academic achievements, particularly in securing internships and educational opportunities.

Sophia believes civic engagement encompasses both active participation and staying informed about local issues. She views it as a responsibility for all citizens, though acknowledging it looks different for each person based on their circumstances and abilities. Her personal approach to civic engagement centers heavily around addressing food insecurity and homelessness. She volunteers weekly at food pantries and community kitchens, finding this work fulfilling and aligned with her values. Sophia volunteers not out of obligation but because it brings her joy and aligns with her identity. While Sophia initially suggests scouting has not directly impacted her civic engagement, deeper reflection reveals its subtle but important influence. She credits scouting with making her more aware of community resources and more willing to explore local services. Sophia's interview answers emphasize several important patterns: her strong commitment to addressing food insecurity and homelessness, the subtle but meaningful influence of scouting on her community awareness, her challenges with time constraints and political engagement, and her growing civic maturity as she progresses through graduate school.

Identification of Themes

As the interviews were conducted, the author began to draw some similarities among the participants. While there were many similarities, they were combined into major categories. The three major themes that emerged were: (a) influences on civic engagement; (b) college's impact on civic engagement; and (c) civic engagement now and later.

Inputs/Theme 1: Influences on Civic Engagement

After interviewing the participants, a better understanding of their lives prior to college emerged. After further questions, two subthemes emerged: (a) how scouting influenced their civic engagement behavior and (b) how their upbringing or families helped guide their civic engagement. These themes came from asking the participants whether they were involved in civic engagement activities prior to pursuing a degree and asking the participants to gauge their civic engagement experiences, activity participation, and leadership of pre-college activities. In addition, participants were asked who influenced their civic behavior and values.

Scouting's Influence on Civic Engagement Behavior

All participants had some sort of introduction to or involvement in civic engagement through their participation in the Scouting program. All participants mentioned doing some sort of community service with their scouting unit. The scouting program has certain rank requirements and merit badges that revolve around civic engagement, providing opportunities for the scouts in the program to be exposed to civic engagement from the onset of their participation. Craig shared:

> Prior to going to college, I would participate in stuff like the forest preserve department. So like there, sometimes we like we're planting like wildflowers in the area, or like lake cleanups, or like, going to feed my serving children, like smaller projects around. But the bulk of it did come through scouting. There are definitely other scouts who have taught me to reach out more, and just like when I have an opportunity to do something, especially with something good, to take it. I would say the same for leaders, as they have encouraged me to get involved, and if I can see that I can do. They gave me the resources to promote me to go do this.

Each participant had a story similar to this one, where their Troop supported a local cause and made it a part of their yearly program plan. However, some also participated in civic engagement activities due to involvement in other extracurricular activities before college. Isla talked about her involvement with the national honor society and school requirements for civic service:

> I was part of the National Honor Society in my high school for their chapter, which involved at least having 4 hours a semester of volunteer work, whether that be helping out other students, or if we did the reunions, or other events. I was a board member of the Gonzaga Society at my high school. We were the group that created the ministries, so the different masses or the different activities that we had on what we called [School Name] values days, and where we learned more about either religion or a specific topic. Within religion, and how that relates to current life. Getting a Catholic education every year, we would have a service day where we went to, I believe it's, the Our Lady of the Angels mission, where they have the food pantry.

This provided significant insight into that while most of the civic engagement activities were done in the scouting program, there were still portions that happened outside. Overall, scouting was the main influence on civic engagement for the group of Eagle Scouts.

Family Influence on Civic Engagement Behavior

In addition to Scouting having an influence on civic engagement behavior, the majority of participants felt that part of their upbringing had impacted their civic engagement behavior. The majority of the participants' lives have been molded by their families, as they have lived with their families for the majority of their lives. Sophia mentioned how she found a civic cause that she now cares deeply about:

> I just did it because for me it was something to do for routine. So, like in high school, every Friday, my mom and I would volunteer at the homeless shelter, and, so, that was just something that we started doing because there was a connection through our local church. We were just looking for something to do, so we did that, and then from there it kind of branched more. I enjoyed doing that, and so I tried to find, you know, like a club to do that with and such. So, it was a. Lot of just getting out there and exploring.

Family help shaped the participant's worldview and espoused family values in the scouts. These values are complementary to the values of the Scouting program. Most families choose to participate due to the alignment of values. Parents are not the only family influence. Edmund mentioned

> I think it comes from scouting, but I think it also comes from the Community. I grew up in. It's very multigenerational, like people don't leave. And so my parents, like, moved into the neighborhood, but that's not very common. Most people, like their parents, grew up there, and their grandparents still live in the town. A lot of my friends that was the case, and so with that sort of multigenerational aspect, everybody, most people feel inclined to give back in some way.

Derek added, "Some of it's definitely for my grandparents. They were very politically involved and kind of passed it on to my father and then on to me a little bit." While most of the influence could be tied to family ties or the scouting program, one individual mentioned that their civic activities were tied to a slight self-serving purpose. Lucas admitted:

> It just felt good, and college applications, everything like that. Like, I feel like a lot of those things were things where I was like, alright, I'm having fun here, and it looks good on the old college resume. That was kind of my sole decision point for a lot of stuff.

Most of the motivators were due to participation in the program, how the service made the participant feel, or the values espoused by the family. Lucas's response seems to be an outlier. However, it is an honest response as to why he chose to participate.

Environment/Theme 2: College's Impact on Civic Engagement

The participants, having done significant amounts of civic engagement activities growing up in the scouting program, arrive at a new environment, the college campus. To better understand how the participants experienced their school environment, I asked questions about their academic environment, campus involvement, the civic environment, the social environment, civic participation off campus, and what the perceived barriers were to participation. The questions tended to point toward four subthemes: (a) engagement with individuals, clubs, and extracurriculars, both on and off campus, (b) participation in civic engagement activities, (c) knowledge about civic engagement around the campus, and (d) the perceived barriers to participation in civic activities. Knowing how they experienced college in comparison to high school provides a deep understanding of how they are adapting to college life.

Engagement with Individuals, Clubs, and Extracurriculars On and Off-Campus

Participation on campus in various clubs or extracurricular activities provides the participants with a pulse of what is going on the campus and in the community at large. Being involved in clubs or extracurricular activities increases the likelihood of the participants being civically engaged. All the participants had some sort of experience interacting with a club or extracurricular activity on campus. While some were "official" members, some just participated because it fit into their schedule, or they wanted to make a difference. Liam had a list of several different clubs that he participated in:

> Chabad, which is a Jewish group, and Hillel, which is another Jewish group, were both available during my freshman year. Then, the Model Arab League, which is like Model United Nations but with the Arab League instead, and Miami Political Review, which was the undergraduate political Science Journal we founded. I was a part of the film society, oh, and then also Alpha Phi Omega. I also did some internships with a local state representative.

A few of the Eagle Scouts were involved with Alpha Phi Omega, a service fraternity with ties to the Scouting program. Alpha Phi Omega is a service fraternity founded in 1925 by Frank Reed Horton and Herbert G. Horton, who was a local scout executive (Horton, *The Founding,* n.d.). Frank Reed Horton's experience at scout camp and exposure to the Scout Oath and Law gave him meaning and a standard and code to live by (Horton, *The Founding,* n.d.). In addition to being active on campus, many of the Eagle Scouts felt that they had positive experiences with their classmates and faculty members on campus. Each Eagle Scout stated that their relationships with classmates and faculty were good. However, some stated that some faculty members were more difficult to talk to than others. Elijah shared about his classmates:

> [The relationship with classmates was] Pretty good. Depends on what kind of class it is. If it's like a big lecture-type class, I'm just in there to do my work. I don't really talk too much, but if it's a smaller class, I'm definitely more active with them.

When it comes to faculty relationships, Marcus stated:

> Professional, but also personal. They are in part because of the atmosphere here at my college. I forget the exact ratio, it's like 20 students to one faculty or something like that. But the professors are knowledgeable about what they teach, but they also make it clear that, like, hey, they care about us as people. There are a couple of faculty members who,

> as I faced graduation, it's going to be difficult saying goodbye to them, and I'm glad that I had the opportunity to meet them and learn from them.

Similar to on-campus activities, off-campus activities could be just as important as participating in clubs or extracurricular activities on campus. A few of the Eagle Scouts mentioned being involved with the Newman Center or being involved in their religious communities. Edmund mentioned:

> Yeah, I'm a Deputy Grand Knight of a Knights of Columbus Council, and then I run a men's group on the side, a Christian men's group. Well, the small group, I just like leading it, and I find it's a good social output, but also a good learning thing. As for the Deputy Grand Knight, I think the men's Christian community is really important, and so it's something I believe is important, and I agree with the values of the organization, and then it's kind of my outflow of scouting into the real world. Like, I get a lot of the very similar scouting values, but not in scouting. So that's kind of nice.

Lucas attends school with Edmund and participates in similar activities, he said:

> I am a member of the Ancient, Free, Accepted Masons of Illinois. So a lot of that's in-person stuff, and that's kind of all over the place. I also volunteer with the Knights of Columbus a lot, but those two are like kind of conflicting as far as membership-wise. So I'm kind of just there helping those folks out, because they do a lot of good, especially the campus group does a lot of good stuff, so I'm there working with them when I can be. I'm engaged with the Catholic Newman Center on campus. I'm not Catholic, but it's the space I'm in, like the faithful I'm at. So they have events and different stuff, and then I go to mass there, trying to think what else I'm doing.

Participation in Civic Engagement Activities

Many of the Eagle Scouts mentioned that they continued to participate in civic engagement activities while at their university. Isla summed up her participation:

> Not to the full extent that I was expecting to. I know that I ended up taking on a lot of courses and credit hours, which definitely impacted my ability to have the free time to go out and do other things. But the one thing I feel I've been pretty consistent with is participating within the Newman Center, or within other religious affiliations and churches around the area. Yeah, to continue in that aspect and build a community within the different parishes that are around here.

Many of the other Eagle Scouts mentioned participating in activities around campus, usually sponsored by the various clubs or organizations they are a part of. Julian shared:

> It was some activities that we put on by the frat, and then some of the like, the major I was in, there were some people that just went out and did it. So, I just went with them, and we did that as well.

Going with the group was a reason why the Eagle Scouts participated when they were in high school; often, their scouting unit added civic engagement activities as part of their monthly meeting plan and thus went with the flow. The same thing happens while in college.

Knowledge About Civic Engagement Around the Campus

As their time in the communities continues, the Eagle Scouts are in tune with the campus community and the greater communities in the towns around them, but knowing is half the battle. The issues reported by ten of the 14 Eagle Scouts paint an interesting image of the campuses and the greater community. While all 14 Eagle Scouts indicated that they felt the

effectiveness of the local government and campus was ok or great. There were a lot of varied issues or community needs. Edmund said this about the issues:

> Housing, the unavailability of housing, and the struggle. So a lot of people super commute now. It's very hard to buy a house in Bloomington. Normal. University funding and the looming strike.

Ambrose added, “I know there are a lot of people in that area who are food insecure. It's one of the biggest places in the state with food insecurity.” Derek provided this context of the issues:

> There, there's a pretty big sexual harassment problem here. We're over 80% male, so it is not great, especially with a maritime culture. And even working with that. And then there's also there there's been incidents with racism and hazing as well. Yeah, I've made more than a few Title IX reports. Which do go to somebody, not sure where.

Adrian said this on the splitting of partnerships:

> I originally signed up to go to Indiana University, Purdue University, Indianapolis. IUPUI and starting this academic year, IU and Purdue divorced. They're no longer together, and so we're still after a 2-year transition period starting my freshman year. The divorce was finalized, and we're still kind of feeling the impact of that. Since a lot of our clubs, our housing, our classrooms, and our buildings are still kind of a little bit in a gray area in terms of everything, and right now we're having a problem of Purdue and IU clubs, housing, and everything conflicting with each other. It's a very noticeable issue if you were close to the IU or Purdue side.

Craig had an example of esteem with his issue regarding project funding and the missed knowledge expansion as a result of the cut funding.

> I think the most pressing one is issues with funding, particularly federal funding. I participate in a lot of research that's funded through NASA and NSF grants, and I would like to do more research that's funded through these programs. We are seeing significant federal cuts that have been directly harming the work that can be done in my university and for people.

Perceived Barriers to Participation in Civic Engagement Activities

Understanding what an Eagle Scout thinks is the reason why individuals do not participate in civic engagement activities, allowing the Eagle Scout to reflect on their own civic engagement. Overwhelmingly, participants mentioned time as a factor for not participating, in addition to lack of information, cost to be involved, and one mentioned self-care. Starting with time as a reason as to why individuals do not participate, Marcus provided a great reason why it was a barrier for him:

> I have to be more aware of, you know, what am I giving my time to? I have to commit so many hours a week to classes, to my homework, to my academics, and I have to set time for myself, for sleep, for meals - to be a human being. So, I have to figure out, you know what? What do I want to focus on? What I'm what am I going to give my time and my effort to? And that's in large part why the organizations that I joined in my freshman year stayed the same pretty much until I graduated, and I didn't really join any others.

Worry about the lack of information or knowledge on a given subject, or perhaps the lack of confidence, is another reason why the Participants felt that individuals do not participate. Isla said:

> Sometimes, especially when it comes to the political aspect, I feel like I don't have enough knowledge on a subject or on a topic to actually go and participate in a

> conversation or in a specific activity that is occurring. Especially if it's going to be something that sparks a debate, where I don't feel like I have the proper information on, because I don't want to be someone who's just saying. Because I said so, or because that's how I feel. But I know that there's a lot of evolving opinions and evolving facts that are occurring within a lot of political topics that I definitely with my lack of news education, don't always have the correct information on.

Sophia added:

> That's why I say it would be a harder thing. So, half the reason why I'm like, not passionate about some stuff, especially when it comes to like, debating politics or like, hot topic issues right now, it's because I'm so busy between classes and work that I just don't have enough time to dig into every single little thing. And so, I'm afraid to talk to people and like, state my opinion because I don't feel educated enough to like, prove that to other people.

The cost of involvement was another issue that the Participants felt was an overwhelming issue. When asked about supporting nonprofit causes, some indicated that they have donated, but many responded with “I am a poor college student.” Sienna describes the choices she has to make:

> I am not able to probably are primarily due to monetary reasons, or just time from exams, or my job. If I am not at my job, I often am taking care of my grandmother, who has Alzheimer's and dementia, and that stuff that happens very last minute, and it sometimes restricts me from doing those kinds of things.

Self-care was the last reason given why individuals do not participate in civic engagement activities. Lucas commented:

> It's not so much my time that is serving as a limiting factor, but more like my mental energy. I feel like when you learn for a living, as you probably experienced some of this yourself lately, working on your degree, right? Like, one of the big parts of your time is spent learning. It's really been beneficial for me to try to limit the amount of stuff I do that I have to think about a lot, which is why I'm like, OK, when it comes to stuff for scouting. If it's just what time do I need to show up, and I will show up if there's a bunch of like other stuff I have to do before I'm not, I can't come help you, 'cause I have too much on the plate. My brain is full, and so if it's like, hey, we're having this big meeting about whatever, something the school is pushing, we're having a few times, cool. I'm there, I'll stand in your meeting, and I'll participate, but if it's like Hey, we need you to write this whole big thing and send, no.

You have to make sure that you have secured your mask before helping others put theirs on.

Outputs/Theme 3: Civic Engagement Now and Later

Understanding the Participants lived experiences, the research question set out to answer how the rank of Eagle Scout influences civic engagement while in college. Looking at current participation and future civic engagement aspirations helps to identify if the rank truly does have an impact on civic engagement. This theme could be grouped into four subthemes: (a) current civic engagement behaviors, (b) civic expression and advocacy, (c) personal development and future orientation, and (d) reflective outcomes.

Current Civic Engagement Behaviors

Continued participation in civic engagement activities will continue to solidify the behaviors of civic engagement. This will ensure that the Participants continue to participate in the future, no matter what the environmental factors. The Participants noted that they had more

time to participate in civic engagement activities while attending college, however, at times they needed to make the decision on how to budget their time. Marcus summarized it best:

> It's[college] provided more opportunities for me to give back and be engaged in the community, but at the same time, I also have to be more aware of, you know, what am I giving my time to? I have to commit so many hours a week to classes, to my homework, to my academics. And I have to set time for myself, for sleep, for meals. To be a human being. So I have to figure out, you know what, what do I want to focus on? What am I going to give my time and my effort to? And that's in large part why?

When asked if being in college made it easier or harder to stay civically engaged, Morgan said:

> In the middle, I can stay civically engaged. It's just a time some of the distance. Being a participant in the college for some of the Civic events, I am not always just around the corner to get there to help with a lot of those activities.

When asked the same question, Lucas stated:

> I feel like a little column A, little column B. I definitely have more time, but I'm definitely less excitable when it comes to going and doing stuff. Like I have more time, but it's harder to get off the couch, and like when I do, I can give more. No, I wake up at 5:00 in the morning for PTI. Never get to bed by 9:00 PM. It doesn't happen. I'm just out of sleep deficit all the time. So, when the great and powerful Edmund is like, Come help at the Food Bank on Saturday, I'm like Awesome, sounds great. What time? He goes.7:00 AM. I'm like, no, no, I'm not gonna do that. So, like when I actually get around to doing things it, it goes a lot better and I'm able to make a bigger impact, but I'm just like, less likely to do a lot of stuff.

Sophia shared how she likes to stay connected with her community:

> I would say it's the thing that, like civic engagement-wise, I've participated in most recently would be one like volunteering at different food pantries and community kitchens. I do that, and then like the other stuff is just because of school, like learning about the Board of trustees, and like what they're currently standing on, and such, but that would probably be it.

While all the Participants could provide examples of their participation in civic engagement activities while in school, Edmund provided some keen insight as to the importance of continued participation while in school, “I think it's important to be informed, and I think the best way to be informed is through our participation.”

Civic Expression and Advocacy

Current participation is important to solidify future participation, but to ensure that society is civically engaged, more than just participants will need to be engaged. This is why the category of Civic Expression and Advocacy is important. If participants can rally their friends, or willing to explain or listen to counter opinions, then as a society, we can grow and continue to do great things. Participants were given a scenario and then asked if they would encourage others to get involved with a cause. Overwhelmingly, many of the Participants felt that encouraging others was important, even if it was just to let others know what their options were. Lucas shared, “Yeah, for sure. If it's important enough that I'm dealing with it, it's important enough to get my homies out there.”

The Participants realized that you cannot be an army of one to make real, substantive change in society. Isla summarized the idea in a succinct manner:

> Yes, I would [encourage others to get involved]. You need more people to actually make a difference. And while a lot of people think that what can their one person actually do for a group of many? But the more people that think that, the less people there are that actually participate in these petitions or protests, which could make it seem like it's less of a more of an insignificant matter than it could actually be. So, expressing your opinion and actually being heard is definitely something that would promote the idea and get other people to have the courage to get out and express their feelings.

Personal Development and Future Orientation

Personal development is also important to future participation in civic engagement. The Participants had the opportunity to do some self-reflection and think about why they participated in civic engagement activities. Adrian reflected and said:

> I believe so, I have. At first, I didn't think it did until I met some more people here, and the amount of distaste there is for public service or community service or anything because so many people don't value that type of service or leadership and like one of my friends would kind of tease me every now and then, like “I can't believe you still do work in scouts for free.” And I’m like, yeah, of course I do, it's a community I love. I'm doing something I believe is important, and I sometimes think I don't know who I would be if I did not believe in just doing things for the greater good.

Some of the other Participants provided reflections on the fact that scouting had brought them to civic engagement, and that is the reason why they are still civically engaged. Derek mentioned:

> Yes. I'd likely be much less involved with my community, and also civically, if I weren't in scouting. I mean, it kind of forced me to be involved to some level, and I think that's also kind of been why I stayed civically active and civically engaged.

Craig also had some insight into why he continued to stay involved civically, “I do, I think my experiences in scouting have led me to seek out more and participate in more civic engagement experiences.”

If you fail to plan, you plan to fail. The same is true of future engagement. If individuals want to stay civically engaged in the future, they need to start planning for their future engagement now. Elijah shared his feelings on being more engaged in the future:

> [I] Think I'll be more civically engaged, especially if I'm in the outdoor space or if I'm in another industry, and that's my career. I want to keep that as my career, and if something poses that, or something in government tries to change what I want to do, then yes, I would. I would need to stay engaged with what I want and what I need in my life, even outside my career. Stuff that maybe affects my friends and my family. I would be more engaged.

Future engagement is also a reflection of their past experiences. Julian chimed in with a reiteration of one of his points, which he made over and over again. Julian said, “I think it's my duty, I mean. I always fall back on, like, someone did it for me, like someone cared enough about me, without even knowing me, to go out and do this.” Liam explained his thoughts on future engagement, expressing a desire to work in the public sector for nonprofits or governmental jobs. Liam explained:

> It's just not to provide for me beyond that, just being able to give back, like the careers I want to pursue are much more altruistic and selfless. I think it's much more about serving the people around you and being able to make an impact.

Looking at the big picture includes thinking about the potential possibilities of running for office to make a greater impact on your community. While some Participants flat out said no, they had

no desire to run for office, several expressed that there are other factors that would come into play when making the decision. When asked if they would run for public office, Sienna shared:

> Yes, I would actually love to. I would think that is great. I actually talked about this to my mother a couple of days ago. We were chatting about what I wanted to do after Graduate School is over, and just about law school and what I wanted to do with that, and yeah, I thought that would be pretty neat.

Reflective Outcomes

The reflective outcomes give a better cross-section of what the rank of Eagle Scout means to those who have earned it. The reflection on being an Eagle Scout and its impact on their daily life does not explain why they participate in civic engagement, but rather explains why they are the person they are. What it means to them gives insight into the importance of the scouting program and provides a tapestry that shapes their worldview and world meaning. I felt that it was important to share several reflections on how the importance of being an Eagle Scout and its impact on their daily lives. Starting with Sienna, she shared:

> I think that being an Eagle Scout was one of the best things to happen to me in my life. I feel like it gives you so many skills that you might not even know about at the moment, but later you're able to build upon and help you in your future career and just your life in general.

Elijah shared:

> To me, a lot. It's shown me so much about what kind of good and bad could be in the world and how we, as individuals, can keep moving forward and just take positions and take leadership in what we can do to keep our community going and keep everything flowing. Because without people in charge, without people wanting to have that like

drive, you know, not much is gonna change. Change is needed, and I think having Participants there and willing to keep stuff moving is great. Again like being an Eagle Scout shows that you know a lot, but it's just a title. It's what you do, it’s how you take what you learn and do, drive it in your life, and help others.

Isla said:

I think one of the things that makes it so important is the people who told me that I couldn't do it. Especially just being a woman and not necessarily being allowed, but also seeing how people who were very against girls even joining the program, and then knowing that they were on my side and cheering for me when I got the rank, and being able to see that progression of knowing that it is OK to evolve and modernize and become a little more associated with the way everything else is and develop. But to know that you know, there's always going to be the stereotypical, crotchety old man, which is, my grandfather was one of those, but to see those guys open up and actually, you know, talk to me about their experiences and want to hear about mine and tell me that I should try something else. That was definitely the best part.

Adrian said:

I think being an Eagle Scout has prepared me for different leadership opportunities that I wouldn't have been otherwise. Like right now, what I've learned from being an Eagle Scout, especially when it comes to being in an organization, setting a vision for everyone, creating goals, and having action plans. That's not a skill everyone has, and I've seen different people of different student organizations say, OK, I'm going to take on this position of leadership and then do absolutely nothing. Or don't really have a direction to

> go or any drive to improve, and I think my experience as an Eagle Scout, especially in the Order of the Arrow, has prepared me to take on different leadership roles. Say, hey, this is my vision, here are my goals, let's cause some change. Let's continue to improve, let's make a difference, and I think that is something that people underestimate the importance of.

Marcus shared:

> I think that being an Eagle Scout is definitely an important part of my life and an important reflection of who I am. But I also believe that whether a person earned Eagle Scout or not is not a full reflection of who they are. I talked to people through college, and I talk about what I do, and I say I'm an Eagle Scout, and sometimes they'll talk about, like, oh, I was in Cub Scouts. Oh, I was in scouting, but I stopped at like Star or Life and I always tell them the same thing. It doesn't matter if you earned Eagle Scout or not. It matters if you take the skills that you learned, the lessons that you learned, and try to apply them in your life outside of scouting. So, I believe that Eagle Scout is in many ways a test of those skills, but it is not a full reflection of that person. But I believe it does tell you a lot about a person if they did earn it.

These reflections help paint a picture of how the Participants view themselves and others in the scouting program. It provides the necessary meaning to the rank and beliefs that they have.

Summary

The Participants provided frank accounts of their experiences inside the scouting program, their feelings on civic engagement, and how they plan to stay civically engaged in the future by examining their past. The semi-structured interviews produced three major themes: (a)

influences civic engagement; (b) college's impact on civic engagement; and (c) civic engagement now and later.

The first theme, influences on civic engagement, showed two subthemes: how scouting influenced their civic engagement behavior and how their upbringing or families helped guide their civic engagement. The Participants shared how they were influenced to be more civically guided by reflecting on past experiences, Scout leaders, and other mentors. They shared how a combination of the scouting program and, often, family support or encouragement shaped their view on civic engagement.

The second theme, College's Impact on Civic Engagement, produced four subthemes: engagement with individuals, clubs, and extracurriculars, both on and off campus, participation in civic engagement activities, knowledge about civic engagement around the campus, and the perceived barriers to participation in civic activities. The Participants got involved in their campus community, participating in clubs and activities both on and off campus. Being involved gave them the opportunity to recharge their mental health. These activities gave the Participants a greater sense of community within their campus.

This section also outlined the continued participation of civic engagement activities as they transitioned to their college campus. The Participants were asked to reflect on their knowledge of the community and to identify some of the issues facing their communities. The Participants showed knowledge that while they may not be able to do a lot to help with solving these issues, they still see the issues happening. The Participants were also asked to reflect on why they do not participate in activities and why they think others do not as well.

The last theme, civic engagement now and later, bore five subthemes: current civic engagement behaviors, civic expression and advocacy, personal development and future

orientation, and reflective outcomes. These themes were a scaffolding of what their future engagement may look like based on the current situations. The Participants rely on their training on a daily basis as contributing members of society. Sharing their thoughts, opinions, and feelings provided a holistic snapshot of the spiderweb of their experiences that is their life. Chapter 5 will further explore the findings of the study, offering some recommendations and considerations for future research. These recommendations may be of benefit to both student and academic affairs professionals by helping them understand the perceived reasons why students do not participate in civic engagement activities, as well as some options for adding additional civic engagement opportunities to their campuses.

Chapter Five: Discussion

This qualitative research study examined the lived experiences and factors contributing to the participation of Eagle Scouts in civic engagement activities while in college. The study provides a better understanding of Eagle Scouts and their civic engagement, which could assist with the development of programming for students. This chapter provides a brief overview of the study, a discussion of findings, implications for practice, and ideas for future research.

Overview of the Study

The participants' experiences were explored using inputs, environment, and outputs to mirror Astin's (1993) I-E-O model. The research study also employed Astin's (1984) student involvement theory to guide the theoretical framework. These frameworks are often used in conjunction with one another. These theories were used to help provide perspectives from the participants to determine their experiences. Astin's theories helped the researcher to answer the research question: How does achieving the rank of Eagle Scout influence involvement in civic engagement while enrolled in a four-year university?

Fourteen Eagle Scouts who were enrolled in public four-year higher education institutions were interviewed via semi structured interviews. The participants shared their feelings and personal experiences before being enrolled at their institution, their feelings on what causes them to want to participate, and the reasons as to why they think others do not participate. Answers varied from participants, however, there were some overarching similarities. The next section provides a discussion of the study's findings.

Discussion of Findings

Civic engagement and leadership development are important topics for higher education, and they were added as elective classifications by the Carnegie Foundation (American Council

on Higher Education, 2024; Driscoll, 2008). Prior experience played an important role in the Eagle Scout's participation after enrolling in a public four-year higher education institution, as suggested by the literature (Soria et al., 2019). The literature also suggested that participation in activities could be impacted by social groups (McCarron et al., 2022).

After interviewing the participants, some themes began to emerge from the study, mainly that (a) influences on civic engagement which had sub themes of (1)how scouting influenced their civic engagement behavior and (2) how their upbringing or families helped guide their civic engagement; (b) college's impact on civic engagement, with the subthemes of (1)engagement with individuals, clubs, and extracurriculars, both on and off campus, (2) participation in civic engagement activities, (3) knowledge about civic engagement around the campus, and (4) the perceived barriers to participation in civic activities; and (c) civic engagement now and later with the subthemes (1) current civic engagement behaviors, (2) civic expression and advocacy, (3) personal development and future orientation, and (4) reflective outcomes.

Inputs: Influences On Civic Engagement

To gather general information about the participants' pre-college experiences, the participants were asked about their Troop, how long they were involved with the troop prior to achieving the rank, and their feelings on the program. Participation in a community-based youth organization such as scouting provided an outlet to learn more about civic engagement (Zarrett et al., 2021). While no two participants were involved in the same troop, each felt that their experience in scouting was positive. Many of the participants also had quite a long history with the organization, with many having over ten years in the program, with one only having a tenure of two years. This supports Kim et al.'s (2016) research that the longer you are involved in the program, the more confidence and competence, which impacts civic engagement.

Participants were also asked about clubs and organizations before college, if they had participated in civic engagement activities before college, and their knowledge and beliefs about civic engagement. This is where some of the answers started to vary amongst participants. The involvement prior to college was varied, with activities such as swimming, drama club, baseball, national honor society, and band, to name a few options. The participants were involved, from being in leadership to being a general member of the organization. While some of these activities also have civic engagement requirements, there is only one consistent organization amongst all the participants, and that is Scouting.

Each participant did, however, share that they got involved with civic engagement activities due to the scouting program. Participants did indicate that while at first, they participated because of scouting, but continued because of their peers, or because they felt the cause was worthwhile. Family also helped shape the participants' views on civic engagement. Sophia, Derek, and Edmund discussed in depth how their family impacted their decision to stay involved. This supports Body's (2022) research that states that civic attitudes are passed down from generation to generation. The research reveals that scouting and family influences worked synergistically rather than independently. Families often choose scouting programs because of values alignment, creating reinforcing systems that support sustained civic engagement.

The findings show both structured (scouting requirements, school mandates) and organic (family traditions, community culture) pathways to civic engagement, suggesting that effective youth civic development benefits from multiple reinforcing influences. The combination of early exposure, peer support, adult mentorship, and family values appears to create a foundation for continued civic engagement beyond the pre-college years, though longitudinal tracking would be needed to confirm sustained impact.

Studying the participants' inputs allows us to comprehend their perceived experience in their environment. Inputs were vital to their success; the only consistent input in all the participants' lives was participation in scouting. Each of the activities prior to college would not be enough to determine their ability (Astin & Antonio, 2012). Thus, the research study gathers information about prior civic engagement experiences to determine if scouting alone or another organization contributed to their participation.

Environment: College's Impact on Civic Engagement

The college environment played a role in the participants' participation in civic engagement. Participants actively participated in various campus organizations and extracurricular activities. Many joined multiple clubs simultaneously, including religious organizations (Chabad, Hillel, Newman Center), service fraternities (Alpha Phi Omega), academic groups (Model Arab League, political science journals), and community organizations (Knights of Columbus, Masonic lodges). Polson et al. (2013) states that those heavily involved in scouting are more likely to be connected to the community later. This involvement in clubs and community organizations helped the participants stay connected to campus life and broader community issues.

While the participants maintained their civic engagement in college, the extent was often less than they had anticipated. Academic demands and increased credit loads significantly impacted their available time for civic activities. High-impact practices were not used as much as anticipated on the college campus. There was a lack of experiential learning across the board, with many participants not aware of what it was, meaning that the institutions are missing out on experiences that could benefit their students (Leupold et al., 2020). The participants, however,

consistently participated in religious and community service activities, often through the organizations they joined.

Many participants followed a pattern similar to their high school experience, participating in group-organized civic activities rather than initiating individual efforts. This suggests that structured, group-based opportunities remain important for sustaining civic engagement. The participants were observed to have a positive attitude and appeared to have a good relationship with others, meaning that their participation may have aided their transition to college (Albright et al., 2020).

The participants demonstrated strong awareness of both campus and local community challenges. They identified various issues, including housing affordability, food insecurity, university funding challenges, gun violence, sexual harassment, racism, hazing, Title IX issues, institutional instability (such as university mergers/separations), freedom of speech concerns, community tensions, and research funding cuts affecting academic and scientific advancement. Despite recognizing these challenges, most participants rated the effectiveness of local government and campus administration as adequate or good.

According to the participants, four primary barriers emerged that limit civic participation among college students: Time Constraints, Information Gaps, Financial Limitations, and Mental Energy Management. Time Constraints were the most frequently cited barrier, as students must balance academic demands, work responsibilities, sleep, meals, and personal care. This forces them to be highly selective about their commitments. In addition, there some participants had a lack of confidence in themselves or their beliefs that aided in their lack of participation.

Many of the participants, particularly regarding political issues, feel insufficiently informed to participate meaningfully in debates or activities. They worry about engaging without

proper knowledge or current information on evolving topics. Not enough knowledge was a reason why individuals often would not participate, as they did not want to look ill-prepared or foolish in front of their peers.

The "poor college student" reality affects their ability to donate to causes or participate in activities requiring fees. Some participants faced additional responsibilities, such as caring for family members, that further limited their availability. While older individuals may also feel the strain financially, many of the participants did not mention having employment to be able to afford the ability to make monetary donations to organizations and causes they care about. Participants recognize the need for self-care and mental health maintenance. The cognitive demands of academic work leave limited mental capacity for additional complex civic engagement activities.

The research conducted reveals that while the participants maintained their civic engagement orientation in college, they face practical constraints that reshape how and when they participate. Their engagement becomes more selective and often relies on existing organizational structures rather than individual initiative. This suggests that colleges seeking to maintain civic engagement among students should focus on reducing barriers through better information sharing, flexible participation options, and integration with existing student activities.

Outputs: Civic Engagement Now and Later

The research conducted showed that all the participants had some idea or notion of being involved in civic engagement now, and they have a commitment to continue to be involved in the future. This directly supports the research stating that scouts will remain involved in their community later in life (Polson et al., 2013). The level of commitment to their ability to

participate was directly correlated to their environment. School work, social life, work commitments, to name a few, all impacted the participants' ability to participate in these activities. Making the choice to participate or not was difficult for the participants, at times weighing on them.

The study also showed that being informed is an additional means for the participants to stay civically engaged as students. Staying informed is the way they see a connection between their involvement and being able to make a difference. The information gained allowed them to better share their stance and make decisions as to participate in civic activities or not. This gained knowledge gave the participants the ability to share with their friends and expand their worldview, and directly impacted their confidence. This lack of confidence altered their self-efficacy, which is a predictor of future action (Urdan, 2006). The knowledge also made the participants feel more at ease talking about the topic, which made them more confident when talking with others about the topic. This made them feel more at ease when encouraging others to participate in certain civic engagement activities.

Participants were asked to reflect on the study and think about their future orientation. Overwhelmingly, the participants felt that it was mostly scouting that brought community engagement to the forefront for many of the participants. However, a desire to help the community and better the world also ranked high for the participants. A better world means that they have a strong civic purpose (Malin et al., 2017). This shows that the foundation has been laid for the participants, and continued support is likely. The participants' participation is contingent on the fact that they feel it is their duty to help the world and make it a better place. This will continue as they go out into the “real world” and become greater contributing members to society.

The last area that the research uncovered was what it meant to be an Eagle Scout to the participants. This provided great insight into who the participants were and how the Scouting Program and being an Eagle Scout shaped their worldview and world meaning. The participants found that being involved in Scouting was one of the greatest experiences of their lives, and many made a commitment to continue in the program into the future if they were not currently involved. Being an Eagle Scout gave them an easy connection to others, as many individuals have some sort of story or connection to the Scouting program through participation as a member, or through partnerships of civic engagement activities with scouting groups. The participants felt that the program provided them with leadership opportunities that they did not receive anywhere else, which allowed them opportunities that non-scouts did not receive. Being an Eagle helps define the participants, but it was not the only thing that defined them.

Implications for Policy and Practice

The transition from high school into college can be a time of change for many students, including a trend to move away from civic engagement activities (Malin et. al., 2017). When times of change occur, it is possible for individuals to search for something they are familiar with to help them feel fulfilled by participating in civic engagement activities (Davignon et al., 2023). The findings of this research study help to create a framework to show the experiences that the Eagle Scouts lived. The evidence gathered presents opportunities for the alteration of policy and practice of higher education institutions, as well as the development of programming to bridge the gap for non-scouts. Higher education institutions can use Eagle Scouts' experiences to develop programming opportunities for their students to ensure that they have a civically engaged student body. Additionally, these implications can spur further discussion of policies and programming to create a more supportive environment for all students enrolled in the university.

Implications for Universities

Higher education institutions have a unique opportunity to build relationships with local councils. This relationship-building could lead to additional recruitment of Eagle Scouts into the university's programs and encourage enrollment. An example of a university using Scouting as a means to build a partnership would be the University of Evansville, who have a Scouting Scholarship for Eagle Scouts and Gold participants (University of Evansville, 2023). While there are others, this is one of the most well-known. In terms of recruitment, there is also Eastern Illinois University, which recently signed a memorandum of understanding with the Greater St. Louis Area Council, which "creates efficient onramps for eligible participants to earn bachelor's and master's degrees" at EIU (Eastern Illinois University, 2024). These partnerships open doors due to the Scouts' membership and allow them additional opportunities that otherwise would not have been there. The relationship is a two-way street that does not exploit the Scouts but rather awards and celebrates their participation in the Scouting program.

Scouts tend to want to help other people at all times, and it can be easy to take advantage of the kindness of scouts. Universities must be cognizant of the relationships that they have with their student-scouts. Scouts could be used as members of the first-year summer program and registration days, campus tour guides, or any number of on-campus employment opportunities. Due to the nature of their training in the scouting program, scouts may tend to be more outgoing, volunteer shifts, or even feel obligated to assist, so the supervisor must be cognizant not to take advantage of the scout.

Implications for Scouting America

Upon completing the study, a couple of points were brought up that could be opportunities for the Scouting America Movement. Scouting America, along with many other

youth-serving community organizations, has felt a dip in membership over the years (Crary, 2021). This can be in part due to lawsuits, changes in membership standards, and shifts in societal norms. As the study progressed, the researcher noticed that all the participants were white. While Scouting America is not comprised solely of white members, much of the membership of Scouting America is white. As a result, Scouting America could work harder on targeting recruitment in more diverse communities to increase membership of underrepresented groups. This recruitment would go a long way to assist those underrepresented groups learn skills that they need to succeed in college but also be active participants in their communities.

Scouting America has done more over the years to target recruitment of underrepresented groups; however, there is still a long way to go to ensure that all have access to the skills and leg up that the Scouting program offers. Many Scouting America councils across the country have programming to support underrepresented groups, but the Pathway to Adventure Council in Chicago, IL, has a program called Restoring the Village. The Restoring the Village Program partners with businesses or community leaders, the Pathway to Adventure Council, and at-risk youth, allowing them the opportunities to learn the values, tools, and mentors needed for a brighter future for them and their community (Pathway to Adventure Council, 2021). While this is not the only method that could be used to provide opportunities to diversify the Scouting program, this is one that has worked and could be replicated.

Influences On Civic Engagement

The research found that there were two major influences on civic engagement: the scouting program and upbringing or familial influences. These two influences mean that there is value in early experiences, and policymakers should do more to attempt to reinforce them. The study participants did not realize the impact that leaders or other scouts had on their civic

engagement until prompted with the question. Most participants had to take some time to think about which leaders and other scouts had impacted their decision to participate in civic engagement activities.

Those who felt that their family played an important role in their civic engagement were able to quickly explain their familial impact on their decision to participate in civic engagement activities, citing how they were raised or influenced by various family members. Craig discussed how his leaders would influence him, but service was part of the rank's requirements, so service meant advancement. Edmund talked about his neighbor’s influence, while Sophia talked about her routine with her mother volunteering at the homeless shelter on Friday nights. Knowing who or what has impacted them provides insight into where their civic engagement started, either prior to or during their involvement in Scouting.

These two influences can be bound together into one overarching category of community. Campuses should not underestimate the power of the community. While community can be used to describe the environment, a previous environment can still impact an individual while in a new environment. Community can also be used to amplify civic habits and institutions can change the community by implementing more service learning and high-impact practices. The dimensions of the participant’s community can be enhanced to counteract their feelings of non-participation (Procentse et al., 2023). In college, one cannot go back and change a previous environment but can influence the current state and environment. Creating a campus environment that is conducive to civic engagement activities by adding service learning and other high-impact learning practices can foster civic engagement while in college. Isla was required to fulfill some community service as part of her National Honor Society involvement.

In Illinois and some other states, this is supported by legislation. Illinois State Statute on required high school courses states that each student entering grade nine starting in the 2016-2017 school year must have "at least one semester must be civics…" (105 Ill. Comp. Stat. 5/27-22, 2024). The use of civic lessons and service learning in the classroom is used nationwide with 41 states requiring civic education and 25 states requiring or providing credit for community service (Shapiro & Brown, 2018). Most college students will have had some civic engagement exposure, which could be amplified by the university.

The current environment will eventually be the past environment and thus an input in the I-E-O College impact model. To ensure that the foundation has been established, the university could also support legislation to ensure that civic engagement is required in high schools. If there were a standard across the board when it comes to civic engagement, service learning, and community service across all 50 states, it would make for a more level playing field. This could be worked on by the Department of Education as a mandate for the states to implement. This is no easy task to accomplish, but it could go a long way toward creating a more equitable starting point for all college students.

College's Impact on Civic Engagement

Participants discussed their school environment and how it shapes their participation in civic engagement activities. Most of the participants said they felt that they had the freedom to participate more; however, Adrian, Ambrose, Derek, Edmund, Elijah, Isla, Lucas, Marcus, and Morgan stated that time was a major factor as to why they did not commit to civic engagement opportunities. The participants noted that they could structure their time better, but school, religious organizations, and other clubs and organizations made them prioritize and pick and choose what to participate in. Whereas when they were in high school, activities were more

structured. This removal of structure provided the participants with some uncertainty. There was a daily schedule set by external factors; now, they have to set their own daily schedule. More time management could provide the opportunity for additional time to devote to civic engagement activities. Additionally, universities could provide opportunities to reinforce or teach time management and prioritization to allow their students to be able to better manage their time and academic careers.

The university provides a rough basis for the participant's schedule, putting into play a schedule of classes selected by the participant to serve as the basis for their weekly schedule. Filling in the other pieces, other activities, work, study time, and civic engagement activities must be added to the schedule by the participant. The university could provide coursework to assist the student in building and managing their schedule, but overall, the purpose is to teach the student responsibility for themselves. This plays into the participant's self-efficacy. Self-efficacy affects the environment you are in and your behavior (Urdan, 2006). This means that to ensure that the participants are successful, they need to have their self-efficacy built up. The university can provide additional leadership coursework or opportunities or service learning to enhance their self-efficacy (Dugan et al., 2011; Leupold et al., 2020). Self-efficacy is important, but so is the coursework that universities offer.

Coursework can also impact the civic engagement of the participants. Previously, it was mentioned that high-impact or service-learning opportunities could be an effective way to ensure that students are exposed and encouraged to participate in civic engagement activities. The Civic Learning for an Engaged Democracy Coalition (CLDE) has partnered with the Higher Learning Commission to help foster civic engagement in the college years (Higher Learning Commission, 2025). The CLDE uses the Civic Learning and Democracy Engagement (CLDE) framework,

which was established in 2024 (Higher Learning Commission, 2025), to foster civic engagement in every student. The CLDE Framework is made up of four aspects, which promote purposeful civic engagement: democratic knowledge and levers for change; bridge-building and problem solving; practical experience and projects; and career-related civic and ethical learning (College Civic Learning, n.d.). These aspects are meant to be built into all curricula to ensure that students can build and grow their civic engagement while attending the university, no matter their major. Implementation of this framework would ensure that students are civically engaged upon graduation. Universities must remember that they have dual roles for their students, educators, and facilitators.

Figure 2

The CLDE Framework for College Civic Learning and Democracy Engagement (College Civic Learning, 2024)

Civic Engagement Now and Later

As participants were asked about civic engagement, they talked about their current engagement, how they express themselves and advocate, how they view their future engagement, and then provided a self-reflection. Participants were overwhelmingly optimistic about their civic engagement levels in their current state and as they look forward to the future. This could be due to their self-efficacy level, as it is a predictor of future actions (Urdan, 2006), or just their sense of duty to their community. Cultivating self-efficacy and reinforcing a community atmosphere can sustain and expand civic engagement into the future. The duty to their community could also be the feeling of being a part of something larger than themselves (Malin et al., 2017). There is no magic wand that can be waved to make their self-efficacy increase or give them the feeling of being a part of something larger than themselves; most of it is self-discovery and growth, which cannot be forced, but can be encouraged. Creating environments on the university campus that support self-discovery would be ideal to support the students. Edmund talked about why he participates in civic engagement activities, and it could be summarized as his way of staying informed and keeping an ear to the community.

The universities could partner with local non-profit organizations to create opportunities for service learning and incorporate them into the curriculum. It would be wise for the university to stay away from the more politically charged organizations and focus more on neutral organizations. Sophia had service learning as part of her undergraduate degree program, and it allowed her to explore opportunities that she normally would not have had the time to experience. The “real world” experience Sophia gained was better than just sitting in a classroom listening to a lecture. These high-impact experiences will contribute to Sophia’s continued and future involvement in civic engagement activities. This could lead to expression and advocacy.

Participation could lead to the discussion with others and the encouragement to get more involved, adding more potential supporters and reach of the organization.

Future plans for civic engagement were high amongst participants. All participants felt that they would continue to participate in civic engagement in the future, with some citing specific causes or organizations that they wish to continue to support. The participants discussed wanting to stay involved with environmental issues, healthcare reform, religious participation, gun reform, women's rights, and food and housing insecurity. While this is a snapshot of the current situation, which has the potential to change in the future, the participants had a wide range. Universities could do a better job to use these experiences as a means to continue engagement post-graduation. It would be hard pressed to find an institution who stated that they have perfect alumni engagement, but many of the participants stated that they would continue to support Scouting into the future through volunteering. These topics are not exclusive to the participants but are issues that are plaguing the United States. The participants seem to have a great pulse on the issues and care about them enough to commit to supporting them long term.

The last area was the self-reflection. Self-reflection is important to growth, and paired with high-impact practices would go a long way for the participants in their own personal development but also their academic achievement (Leupold et al., 2020). Participants felt that being an Eagle Scout was important, but was not the defining aspect. They are more than just an Eagle Scout; they are friends, siblings, colleagues, and more. The participants did feel that the skills learned have helped them; however, they are skills they could have learned from other organizations. Participation showed Elijah the good and bad in the world and how to navigate through it. It taught Isla how there are more people rooting for her than hoping she fails in a male-dominated organization. Most of the discussion in this section related back to their

leadership abilities and their self-efficacy. This provided deep insight into just how the scouting program helped shape their self-confidence and abilities. Scouting develops individuals and provides leadership and mentoring to those involved, which is a high-impact practice (Leupold et al., 2020). These practices shape the scouts and ensure they are "Prepared. For Life."

Future Research

The research in the study examined the lived experiences of Eagle Scouts and their civic engagement in college. The study examined 14 Eagle Scouts who were in college or are recent graduates of a public four-year university. With the limitations of the study in mind, there are some implications for future research for the academic community. These future findings can expand the knowledge of Eagle Scouts and scouting in general on those who choose to participate in the program. Creating a greater understanding of how the program impacts participants.

After reviewing and analyzing the data, there were some areas that could potentially lead to further research on the topic of Eagle Scouts. The first being an examination of Eagle Scouts from a varied ethnic background. Examining varied ethnic backgrounds could provide a better picture of the lived experiences of Eagle Scouts and provide a better cross-section of the program's impact on civic engagement. This could open up analysis on the lived experiences of the minority groups in Scouting America. This could only enhance the research and give a greater picture of the topic of Eagle Scouts and civic engagement.

In addition to examining different minority groups, the study could also be opened up to those Eagle Scouts who are enrolled in community colleges or private four-year institutions. Expanding the pool of institutions to pull from would allow for a greater distribution of experiences of the Eagle Scouts. This would provide the research with a greater pool to select

from, a broader view of experiences and feelings that could aid the research in the future. This could help the development of civic engagement opportunities on the college campus.

A third area of future research would be Eagle Scouts, or in general, scouts, and their academic achievement. It has often been said that scouts are better students; however, there is little research to support this notion. This research would be helpful to paint a picture of the scout's experience in school. This study would have to involve parental consent and additional measures to protect the participants due to the age range of scouts (six to eighteen). That would provide some insight as to how the scouting program makes the scouts better students. This could shed light on whether there is anything that could be done to level the playing field for non-scouts. This would give a better understanding of the scouting program's impact on student performance, if any exists.

A fourth area of future research would be to examine the community needs using Maslow's hierarchy of needs. In the study, the needs of the community were examined and could have been formulated using Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs. This grouping of community or personal needs could influence and shape how the Eagle Scouts participate. Research could then be conducted to see if Eagle Scouts are more likely to participate in civic engagement activities depending on where it falls on the hierarchy of needs. This would provide some great knowledge on participation and allow colleges to select civic engagement activities based on where they fall on the hierarchy of needs.

Lastly, future research could be conducted on Eagle Scouts who opt not to pursue higher education and examine their civic engagement. Eagle Scouts who are in trade schools, apprenticeship programs, or those who went straight into the workforce would be examined. This would add to the knowledge base of Eagle Scouts overall.

Conclusion

Eagle Scouts have lived full lives that have directly impacted their unique experiences, perspectives, and civic engagement participation. Their stories should be told and heard to understand fully the impact of being an Eagle Scout has on civic engagement. Civic engagement is and will continue to be important to the higher education landscape; however, this study aimed to view the lived experiences of Eagle Scouts to determine if there was anything in the Scouting program that could be used and adapted to create programming on a university campus. Results from this study found some shared meaning, experiences, feelings, and ideas of why Eagle Scouts participated, and how they chose to participate. Themes included: (a) influences on civic engagement; (b) college's impact on civic engagement; and (c) civic engagement now and later. By recording their lived experiences, this study provided practical implications for higher education institutions to provide and encourage civic engagement activities. The research encourages universities to encourage and implement more opportunities for civic engagement through changes to university policies, programming, and practices.

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APPENDIX A

CURRENT EAGLE SCOUT RANK REQUIREMENTS

EAGLE RANK REQUIREMENTS

✓			LEADER INITIAL & DATE
	1.	Be active in your troop for at least six months as a Life Scout. *(See page 24.)*	
	2.	As a Life Scout, demonstrate Scout Spirit by living the Scout Oath and Scout Law. Tell how you have done your duty to God, how you have lived the Scout Oath and Scout Law in your everyday life, and how your understanding of the Scout Oath and Scout Law will guide your life in the future. List on your Eagle Scout Rank Application the names of individuals who know you personally and would be willing to provide a recommendation on your behalf, including parents/guardians, religious (if not affiliated with an organized religion, then the parent or guardian provides this reference), educational, employer (if employed), and two other references. *(See pages 11–16, 23, and 415.)*	
	3.	Earn a total of 21 merit badges (10 more than required for the Life rank), including these 14 merit badges: (a) First Aid, (b) Citizenship in the Community, (c) Citizenship in the Nation, (d) Citizenship in Society, (e) Citizenship in the World, (f) Communication, (g) Cooking, (h) Personal Fitness, (i) Emergency Preparedness OR Lifesaving, (j) Environmental Science OR Sustainability, (k) Personal Management, (l) Swimming OR Hiking OR Cycling, (m) Camping, and (n) Family Life. You must choose only one of the merit badges listed in categories i, j, and l. Any additional merit badge(s) earned in those categories may be counted as one of your seven optional merit badges used to make your total of 21. *(See pages 28 and 416–419.)*	
		NAME OF MERIT BADGE — DATE EARNED	
		1.	
		2.	
		3.	
		4.	
		5.	
		6.	
		7.	
		8.	
		9.	
		10.	
	4.	While a Life Scout, serve actively in your troop for six months in one or more of the following positions of responsibility[11]: *(See pages 422–425.)* **Scout troop.** Patrol leader, assistant senior patrol leader, senior patrol leader, troop guide, Order of the Arrow troop representative, den chief, scribe, librarian, historian, quartermaster, junior assistant Scoutmaster, chaplain aide, instructor, webmaster, or outdoor ethics guide. **Venturing crew/Sea Scout ship.** President, vice president, secretary, treasurer, quartermaster, historian, den chief, guide, boatswain, boatswain's mate, yeoman, purser, storekeeper, chaplain aide, outdoor ethics guide, crew leader, media specialist, specialist or webmaster. **Lone Scout.** Leadership responsibility in your school, religious organization, club, or elsewhere in your community.	

[11] *Assistant patrol leader and bugler are not approved positions of responsibility for the Eagle Scout rank. Likewise, a Scoutmaster-approved leadership project cannot be used in lieu of serving in a position of responsibility.*

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✓			LEADER INITIAL & DATE
	5.	While a Life Scout, plan, develop, and give leadership to others in a service project helpful to any religious institution, any school, or your community. [The project must benefit an organization other than Scouting America.] A project proposal must be approved by the organization benefiting from the effort, your Scoutmaster and unit committee, and the council or district before you start. You must use the *Eagle Scout Service Project Workbook*, Scouting America publication No. 512-927, in meeting this requirement. (To learn more about the Eagle Scout service project, see the *Guide to Advancement*, topics 9.0.2.0 through 9.0.2.16.) [See pages 418–419.]	
	6.	While a Life Scout, participate in a Scoutmaster conference. [See page 418.]	
In preparation for your board of review, prepare and attach to your Eagle Scout Rank Application a statement of your ambitions and life purpose and a listing of positions held in your religious institution, school, camp, community, or other organizations, during which you demonstrated leadership skills. Include honors and awards received during this service.			
	7.	Successfully complete your board of review for the Eagle Scout rank.[12] [This requirement may be met after age 18, in accordance with *Guide to Advancement* topic 8.0.3.1.[13]). [See page 414.]	

Notes: *For Venturers working on Scouts BSA requirements, replace "troop" with "crew" and "Scoutmaster" with "crew Advisor." For Sea Scouts working on Scouts BSA requirements, replace "troop" with "ship" and "Scoutmaster" with "Skipper."*

[12]*APPEALS AND EXTENSIONS*

If a Scout believes all requirements for the Eagle Scout rank have been completed but a board of review is denied, the Scout may request a board of review under disputed circumstances in accordance with Guide to Advancement topic 8.0.3.2.

If the board of review does not approve the Scout's advancement, the decision may be appealed in accordance with Guide to Advancement topic 8.0.4.0.

If a Scout foresees that, due to no fault or choice of their own, it will not be possible to complete the Eagle Scout rank requirements before age 18, the Scout may apply for a limited time extension in accordance with Guide to Advancement topic 9.0.4.0. Time extensions are rarely granted and reserved only for work on Eagle.

[13]*AGE REQUIREMENT ELIGIBILITY*

Merit badges, badges of rank, and Eagle Palms may be earned by a registered Scout or a qualified Venturer or Sea Scout. Scouts may earn these awards until their 18th birthday. Any Venturer or Sea Scout who has achieved the First Class rank as a Scout in a troop may continue working up to their 18th birthday toward the Star, Life, and Eagle Scout ranks and Eagle Palms.

An Eagle Scout board of review may occur, without special approval, within 24 months after the 18th birthday. ***Consult the Guide to Advancement topic 8.0.3.1, if a Board of Review is to be conducted more than 24 months after the candidate's 18th birthday.***

If you have a permanent physical or mental disability, or a disability expected to last more than two years or beyond age 18, you may become an Eagle Scout by qualifying for as many required merit badges as you can and qualifying for alternative merit badges for the rest. If you seek to become an Eagle Scout under this procedure, you must submit a special application to your local council service center. Your application must be approved by your council advancement committee ***before you can work on alternative merit badges.***

A Scout or Venturer with a disability may also qualify to work toward rank advancement after reaching 18 years of age if the guidelines outlined in section 10 of the Guide to Advancement are met.

APPENDIX B

ELIGIBILITY EMAIL

Dear (Participant Name),

Greetings! I would like to thank you for taking the time to submit your interest in participating in this study. In reviewing the criteria and the information you provided, it is evident that you qualify for participation in the study. Attached to this email is a consent form for your review. During our initial interview, we will talk though the form and what I means to you.

The next step for participation would be to schedule a time for the initial interview. You can schedule a time using the link below (Link to scheduling a time). Interviews will be conducted via (name of video conference software being utilized). Once the initial interview is scheduled the link will be provided.

Again, I would like to say thank you in advance for your participation, and please let me know of any questions, comments, or concerns.

Regards,

Blaise A. Lukasiewicz, MSTD (Eagle Scout Class of 2007)
Doctoral Student, Interdisciplinary Studies
Higher Education Administration
College of Education and Human Potential
Governors State University
1 University Parkway
University Park, IL 60484
blukasiewicz@govst.edu

APPENDIX C

NON-ELIGIBILITY EMAIL

Dear (Person's Name),

Greetings! I would like to thank you for taking the time to submit your interest in participating in this study on Eagle Scouts and civic engagement in college. In reviewing the criteria and the information you provided, you unfortunately do not qualify for participation in the study because (Insert note of denial from the list below). We will be deleting and destroying any personal information that was provided on the initial interest form. I can say that I do appreciate you being "helpful" and willing to "help other people at all times."

Regards,

Blaise A. Lukasiewicz, MSTD (Eagle Scout Class of 2007)
Doctoral Student, Interdisciplinary Studies
Higher Education Administration
College of Education and Human Potential
Governors State University
1 University Parkway
University Park, IL 60484
blukasiewicz@govst.edu

(For not meeting the criteria, one of the following will be inserted into the email template above:

a. You have not yet earned the rank of Eagle Scout in Scouting America.
b. You are not currently enrolled in a public four-year higher education institution.
c. You have not yet completed your first year of college (freshman year).
d. You can not fulfil the required time commitment for participation.)

APPENDIX D

SOCIAL MEDIA POSTS

A scout is Helpful and should be willing to help other people at all times. I am seeking recent Eagle scouts for participation in my research study. These scouts should have completed 30 credit hours at a public four-year higher education institution. Being an Eagle Scout has the potential to impact a student's ability to achieve academically and participate in civic engagement activities.

Individuals who identify as someone who (1) has earned the rank of Eagle Scout; (2) is currently enrolled in a public four-year higher education institution; (3) completed their first year of study (freshman year); (4) has the ability to participate in potential multiple interview sessions.

If you qualify for participation in the study, please complete the following survey:

https://forms.office.com/r/qSLJV4mcE3 or email me at blukasiewicz@govst.edu. I will share additional information about the study at that time. Interviews will be conducted in the months of April/May 2025.

Thank you for your consideration!

Blaise A. Lukasiewicz, MSTD (Eagle Scout Class of 2007)
Doctoral Candidate, Interdisciplinary Studies
Higher Education Administration
College of Education and Human Potential
Governors State University

Be mindful that items on the internet are out there to be viewed by anyone. Interaction with my post is appreciated, but be mindful that someone may gain knowledge of your interest or participation in this study.

APPENDIX E

EMAIL TO THE EXECUTIVE STAFF AT THE PATHWAY TO ADVENTURE COUNCIL, BSA

Greetings (Name of PTAC Staff member), I am seeking your assistance with sharing information about my upcoming research study on Eagle Scouts and civic engagement in college. Below you will find an email to send to your contacts to assist with recruitment. This email also contains important information about the study. I appreciate your consideration and assistance in this matter.

Dear Scout,

I am a doctoral candidate at Governors State University, and I am writing to you as you may qualify as a participant for my research study. Below I will go into further detail about study being conducted and criteria for participation.

My capstone project will focus on examining how earning the rank of Eagle Scout in Scouting America can impact civic engagement in college. We know that earning the rank of Eagle Scout is an achievement of praise, but we want to know what happens when the scout attends college for the first time. I am hoping to interview 10-20 Eagle Scouts during the months of April and May of 2025. Participation in the study is voluntary and confidential. I am hoping that several scouts will heed the call to "help other people at all times."

Participation in the study would include participation in a qualifying survey (less than 10 minutes), a maximum of two interview sessions lasting between 60 to 90 minutes in length, reviewing the transcripts from the interview(s) (Approximately 60 minutes), and reviewing my findings from your participation (approximately 60 minutes). Involvement in this study will span approximately six months or less, and an approximate total time commitment of up to four hours.

Eligibility in this study is limited to scouts who meet the following criteria:

- Eagle Scout
- Enrolled in a public four-year higher education institution.
- Completed your first year of college (freshman year)
- Ability to meet the time commitment for participation in the study.

If you are interested in being considered for participation in the study, or would like more information about the study, please contact me, Blaise A. Lukasiewicz, at blukasiewicz@govst.edu. Any questions pertaining to the conducting of the study or their rights as a research participant you can contact the Governors State University Institutional Review Board IRB@govst.edu or 708.534.4987.

Thank you for your consideration in this matter.

Blaise A. Lukasiewicz, MSTD (Eagle Scout Class of 2007)
Doctoral Candidate, Interdisciplinary Studies Higher Education Administration
College of Education and Human Potential, Governors State University
blukasiewicz@govst.edu

APPENDIX F

EMAIL TO REFERRED PARTICIPANTS

Dear (Referred individual Name),

I am a doctoral candidate at Governors State University, and I am writing to you because you may be eligible to be a participant in my research study. A fellow scout referred you; I ask that you review the information below about the study and criteria for participation.

My capstone project will focus on examining how earning the rank of Eagle Scout in Scouting America can impact civic engagement in college. We know that earning the rank of Eagle Scout is an achievement of praise, but we want to know what happens when the scout attends college for the first time. I am hoping to interview 10-20 Eagle Scouts during the months of April and May of 2025. Participation in the study is voluntary and confidential. I am hoping that several scouts will heed the call to "help other people at all times."

Participation in the study would include participation in a qualifying survey (less than 10 minutes), a maximum of two interview sessions lasting between 60 to 90 minutes in length, reviewing the transcripts from the interview(s) (Approximately 60 minutes), and reviewing my findings from your participation (approximately 60 minutes). Involvement in this study will span approximately six months or less, and an approximate total time commitment of up to four hours.

Eligibility in this study is limited to scouts who meet the following criteria:

- Eagle Scout
- Enrolled in a public four-year higher education institution.
- Completed your first year of college (freshman year)
- Ability to meet the time commitment for participation in the study.

If you are interested in being considered for participation in the study, or would like more information about the study, please contact me, Blaise A. Lukasiewicz, at blukasiewicz@govst.edu. Any questions pertaining to the conducting of the study or their rights as a research participant you can contact the Governors State University Institutional Review Board IRB@govst.edu or 708.534.4987.

Thank you for your consideration in this matter.

Blaise A. Lukasiewicz, MSTD (Eagle Scout Class of 2007)
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